

House of Dog

written by

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FADE IN:

EXT. RILKE'S SPOT (KISSIMMEE PRAIRIE) - DAY

A bucolic paradise in Florida dry prairie. A light breeze flows through tall grass while sheep roam and bees buzz between wild flowers. Calmness permeates.

Rilke, an old, male German Shepherd Dog, lies comfortably in the grass while gazing upon the pastoral scene.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "HOUSE OF DOG"

BACK TO RILKE

Rilke, suddenly disturbed, agitated, sits up and looks at the camera, panting, eyes distraught.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "Ten Years Before the Death of the Baroness"

EXT. ESTATE (KISSIMMEE PRAIRIE) - DAY

A large, imposing French Baroque estate sits alone, visible for miles in Florida dry prairie. The house casts shadows over the pristine tennis court, French garden, and horse stables. It appears still.

INT. ESTATE / BARONESS' ROOM - DAY

A sunny, ornate bedroom of the French Baroque estate: silky canopy bed, antique furniture, realist paintings with intricate frames, ornate ceiling. A modern sensory deprivation chamber sits conspicuously in the room.

The top of the sense-dep chamber opens, revealing a naked BARONESS EHRLICH, 70s, an elegant, sly, old-world matron. Baroness reviews her surroundings coldly.

INT. ESTATE / PORTRAITS HALLWAY - DAY

Baroness, wearing exercise clothes, walks through a Baroque hallway filled with portraits of German Shepherds.

INT. ESTATE / BALLET ROOM - DAY

A ballet room with standard mirror walls. Baroness does low-impact exercises before the mirrors.

INT. ESTATE / PORTRAITS HALLWAY - DAY

Baroness, wearing her exercise clothes, slightly sweaty, walks the other way past the German Shepherd portraits.

EXT. ESTATE / DRIVEWAY - DAY

DOUG, late 20s, walks up a long driveway toward the looming French Baroque estate. He wears a "Big Dog" T-shirt that reads "I'm My Own Good Truck Charm" and cargo shorts.

An odd delivery robot, small with four wheels, that's been fitted with a tennis ball launcher, zooms down the driveway toward Doug. The launcher rapidly spits out oranges as it passes by Doug, one hitting him in the stomach. Doug winces, pauses, and continues on.

INT. ESTATE / BARONESS' ROOM - DAY

Baroness gets dressed with the help of a maid. A doorbell sound is heard, though Baroness appears unperturbed.

INT. ESTATE / SALON - DAY

Baroness, in formal attire, sits on a large chaise longue. Rilke has his head in her lap.

A servant shows Doug in to the room; he's still in his "Big Dog" shirt and shorts. He sits down on a chair facing the Baroness.

DOUG

Thank you for seeing me impromptu,
madam.

BARONESS

I've gotten bored with the other
buttoned-up butter-uppers. Your
exotic appearance, both of your
person and on my doorstep, piqued
me enough. You see, Mr. Fennel ...

DOUG

(interrupting)
Please, madam baroness. "Mr."
(MORE)

DOUG (CONT'D)

Fennel" was my dad's parakeet. Call me "Doug".

BARONESS

Very well, Doug. You see, Doug, my dog deserves the darnedest care. The utter darnedest, Doug. And I'll be darned, utterly stitched up, to see him in woe of it.

DOUG

I understand completely, madam. I honestly believe our animals are our betters and have purer souls than we. We are merely their stewards.

BARONESS

Is that so.

Doug holds back tears. Rilke dozes off.

DOUG

Yes, baroness.

BARONESS

We humans do thumb along wretched, Mr. Fennel, despite our noses.

DOUG

I agree; we do thump along.

BARONESS

Your statement might seem "pablumatic" to some.

DOUG

Ma'am?

BARONESS

It's "Madam", Doug. This dog, here, is a German Shepherd, with breeding documentation on both sides going back to Max von Stephanitz' first dog, Horand von Grafrath. This breed he, Stephanitz, with concentrated, shrewd effort, collated from varying strands of sheep-mutt DNA to pistolwhip together a dog keen enough to sniff out cocaine and clever enough to lead the blind. This ...

DOUG
(interrupting)
I didn't know that.

BARONESS
This particular specimen on my lap has already won three intelligence competitions, the most recent of which required him to correctly slot ten wooden shapes into an equal number of their respective holes, those holes being distributed around an enclosure of 500 square feet, something my boy Morgan couldn't have done handily until 5 years old, and, even then, with stumbling. You're ...

DOUG
(interrupting)
That's very impressive, ma'am ...
madam.

BARONESS
You're right that we are, I am, his steward, and he is my ward, but we protect not his dogged dog-ness, not his soul or being, but a doggy technology, sealed in matter red and gray, dearly developed by our own, human, utterly human, forbears.

Rilke perks up and barks. Baroness pets him.

DOUG
Yes, madam, as true as that is, I'm sure that you'll find no one better than I to protect this precious animal.

MARGOT EHRLICH, mid 30s, the Baroness's daughter, an attractive but unkempt tech-girl, enters in haphazard horse-riding gear. She holds a large remote control for her orange-shooting delivery robot.

MARGOT
Mother, what are you on about.

BARONESS
Oh nothing, dear. Just rizzing this young idiot, Doug Fennel. He's here for the dog-man role.

DOUG
Baroness?

MARGOT
Hello, young idiot.

DOUG
Hello. What was it ... Morgan?

MARGOT
Max von Stephanitz was a fucking
smokeshow.

BARONESS
No. This is my younger, Margot.

MARGOT
Don't neglect to tell him about the
dog's masturbation schedule. Cum he
regular, that dog.

BARONESS
Margot! You know that's ignoble:
all that happens 'tween a canine's
paws, wide eyes and mum mouths will
ever cause.

Margot smirks and faux claps.

DOUG
(jumping in)
You like Shakespeare, madam?

BARONESS
The bard? Again, pablumatic.

DOUG
My apologies, madam. In any case,
you must know that a dog's general
vitality can actually be monitored
by his ... sexual neediness ...

MARGOT
What the fuck, Doug-o-tron. Are you
trying to get this dog's un-
neutered rocks off?

DOUG
(scrambling)
No ... no, of course ...

BARONESS
Oh dear, dear Doug. You were doing
well enough.

DOUG

Madam, I swear, whatever our
potential philosophical
disagreements ...

MARGOT

(interrupting)

He's not catching up, mother ...

DOUG

... I assure you that no one will
give more attentive care to this
dog than I.

BARONESS

Yes, well, that I believe, at least
up to your limitations, anyway. You
claim to be some kind of "psychic",
too?

DOUG

Yes, madam. I've sometimes stumbled
across certain psychic connections,
pathways, if you will, with
animals. I think I may have found
one with Rilke.

MARGOT

Mother, you know what happened last
time we ingratiated some schizofunk
loosey into our tranquil domus.

Margot looks at Doug and mimes slicing her own throat.

BARONESS

Alright, that's enough theatrics,
Margot. Doug, we'll put you on for
a three-month trial, highly
supervised, if ...

DOUG

(interrupting)

Thank you so much, madam.

BARONESS

... if you can tell us, right now,
Rilke's favorite food ...

Doug closes his eyes and breathes slowly. An adult American
alligator, wearing a collar and a ring around one of its
front fingers, appears next to the chaise longue: it's
Pebbles, Doug's former pet. Baroness and Margot watch him
with skepticism.

MORGAN EHRLICH, early 40s, Baroness' son, a successful businessman, rakishly handsome, enters the room. He's confused by the scene.

MORGAN

Mother ... I'm off to London ...

They ignore him. Margot, using her remote control, sneaks the tennis robot into the room and parks it in front of Doug, launcher directed at his face.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "Five Years Before the Death of the Baroness"

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - DAY

Doug, older, now in sleek, minimalist clothing, stands holding a heart of romaine covered in peanut butter; Rilke, bigger, chews on it.

Some cooks are preparing food in the background. Baroness walks in wearing her exercise clothes.

DOUG

You did an excellent job on the court today, Rilke.

BARONESS

I must say, Doug, despite my disquieting suspicion, this tennis regimen seems to be doing wonders for Rilke's physique and spirit. That pro you found is charmed.

DOUG

Yes, madam, Gunther's lovely. And Rilke loves a well-manicured green, like his mother.

BARONESS

You go too far, young idiot. Where are we at on the bitch?

DOUG

Sorry, madam. Yes, I'm still searching for a suitable bitch. It's difficult.

BARONESS

Only the best bitch will do, considering the prior fiasco ...

DOUG
According to the gift which
bounteous nature hath in him
closed.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Margot searches the fridge for a midnight snack.

GUNTHER, Doug's lover, an aging German tennis pro, walks in
naked with Doug on a leash and in a gimp costume.

Margot sees them and shuffles out of sight.

GUNTHER
Meine Maus, you are my pet, and
this land is fertile.

INT. ESTATE / SALON - DAY

Doug and Baroness sit on the chaise longue. Rilke sits on the
floor in front of Doug, with his paws in Doug's lap. Doug
clips Rilke's nails.

Margot enters pulling a small, wheeled table with a leash. On
the table is a laptop and a digital camera. The camera's
circuit board is showing, and Margot has hooked her laptop up
to the camera to program it.

Margot finds a chair and starts coding.

MARGOT
We are truly blessed, mother.

BARONESS
Suddenly so sanguine, dear Margot.
Do you have a worm?

MARGOT
Not more than average. I'm just
reflecting on what fertile land we
have here, and such a nice pet.

Doug looks at Margot nervously.

BARONESS
What are you on about?

MARGOT
Nothing of import, mother.

DOUG
A truly horsey kingdom, ma'am.

MARGOT
Young idiot strikes again.

BARONESS
Do shut up, Margot.

Margot closes her laptop and pulls her effects out of the room. Doug continues clipping.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "Six Months Before the Death of the Baroness"

INT. ESTATE / BARONESS' ROOM - DAY

Shades are drawn. Baroness, on death's door, sleeps in bed. She wears an oxygen mask and her heart rate is monitored.

Doug and Rilke, both older, sit by her side, Rilke's head on the bed. A nurse prepares a syringe at a dresser.

Margot, now early 40s, walks in.

MARGOT
I want to sit alone with my mother.

Doug makes to get up, but Baroness partially wakes up and takes Doug's hand, wheezing.

Margot gives Doug an angry look and walks out.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "The Death of the Baroness"

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER (FLASHING): "RED ALERT"

INT. OFFICE (LONDON) - DAY

Morgan, now early 50s, sits up naked in his own sensory deprivation chamber. The "RED ALERT" warning is seen flashing on the inside of the sense-dep door.

The chamber sits in the well-windowed office of a high-rise tower in London.

STINGER, 60s, Morgan's wry English personal aide, hands Morgan a towel as he exits the sense-dep chamber.

MORGAN
Stinger, it's occurring?

STINGER
It's near occurred, sir; a mere handful of her breaths remain.

Morgan gets dressed into a sleek suit with Stinger's aid.

MORGAN
It's inopportune.

STINGER
It's unfortunate, sir.

MORGAN
It's inopportune-ass.

STINGER
Inconvenient ...

MORGAN
Ill-fucking-fated.

STINGER
Quite fated, sir. My condolences.

MORGAN
Alright. Cancel my lunch with Saudi-Cloudi and schedule me a plane to Florida.

STINGER
Your helicopter will arrive in 10 minutes, sir, airport-routed.

MORGAN
Okay. And get me a little Marmite, for Margot's unreasonable predilection.

STINGER
It's in your luggage, sir.

MORGAN
I'll see you after the matrimortal shitstorm.

STINGER
I'm champing, sir.

MORGAN
Inconvenient my sweet ass.

INT. GOON'S STORE (ORLANDO) - DAY

A used electronics store. Metal shelving; wires, computers, and cameras strewn about everywhere, much half-broken. The delivery robot, with the tennis ball launcher attached, sits dusty in a corner.

Margot sits in a hoodie coding on a computer.

The store owners, WORM and SNAKE, two goon-like savants in their 30s, sit nearby, soldering something on a laptop. Worm is dishevelled and erratic, while Snake is relatively buttoned down and calm. They wear identical coveralls.

A "virus" screen takes over Margot's laptop: a red skull-and-crossbones on a black screen, and underneath flash the words "RED ALERT".

MARGOT
Loser-trons ... it's occurring.

WORM & SNAKE
(together)
What the?

MARGOT
Mumsy's on dead alert, boys.

Margot shows them her laptop. All three look at each other.

WORM & SNAKE
(together)
Loser-trons ... it's occurring.

The soldering gun sparks.

INT. ESTATE / HORSE STABLES - DAY

A hay-floored barn with an even number of stables arranged in parallel across from each other, with an aisle in between. Three or four stables have calm horses.

Doug sits cross-legged with eyes closed in the aisle, face directed down the aisle. The horses' heads hang above him.

At one end of the barn, facing Doug, sits Pebbles.

His phone makes an odd alarm sound, and he opens his eyes. The horses whinny. He looks at his phone: "RED ALERT". Pebbles is no longer there.

DOUG
It's occurring.

Doug runs out of the barn.

EXT. ESTATE / FRENCH GARDEN - DAY

Doug walks briskly across an elaborate French garden. A groundskeeper is trimming hedges. A tennis court is visible from the garden.

EXT. ESTATE / PATIO - DAY

Doug enters the French Baroque mansion from an expansive patio. An obvious helicopter pad sits near the patio.

INT. ESTATE / PORTRAITS HALLWAY - DAY

Doug continues through another Baroque hallway filled with portraits of German Shepherds.

INT. ESTATE / RILKE'S ROOM - DAY

Doug enters Rilke's bedroom, which has realistic-looking sheep wallpaper and a window.

Rilke lies sleeping on a silky canopy bed. Against one wall lies a large, electronically operated bureau.

Doug eyes Rilke with pity and heads to the bureau.

DOUG
Rilke, my sweet one, it's
occurring.

Doug fiddles with the bureau's buttons, causing a display to cycle through a variety of ornate dog treats. Doug picks a peanut-butter-based treat and takes it from a dispenser.

Doug walks over to Rilke and presents the treat. Rilke wakes up, whimpers, and licks the treat from Doug's hand.

DOUG
Rilke, my king, it's time to offer
our farewells.

Doug pets Rilke in silence as Rilke chews.

EXT. ESTATE (KISSIMMEE PRAIRIE) - DAY

The estate looms as a helicopter approaches.

EXT. ESTATE / PATIO - DAY

The helicopter lands on the pad near the patio of the estate. Morgan calmly exits the helicopter.

Margot sits unperturbed on a bench on the patio. Morgan walks up to her, greets her with kisses, and sits next to her.

INT. CATHEDRAL (ORLANDO) - DAY

A gloomy, stone cathedral where the funeral is about to start. People hazard their way into the wooden pews.

Near the altar is Baroness's sense-dep chamber serving as the casket. Next to it is an easel with a large poster-board that reads "The Baroness", but there are no other pictures.

Rilke, Doug, Morgan, and Margot sit in the front row. One row behind them sit Gunther and workers from the estate.

Doug rests his hand on Rilke's back. Margot listens to horse racing via earpods. Morgan elbows Margot in the ribs.

MORGAN

Nix your noisers.

MARGOT

Pods life, bitch.

MORGAN

You'll attend to Dante's Florentine
dick one fine day.

MARGOT

Shut up eggface. I'll save you the
slime.

MORGAN

Slurp off.

MARGOT

I need them on.

MORGAN

I stagger to believe.

MARGOT

Look, I slapped some smack down on
a dark darby nag this morn.

Morgan takes Margot's pods out. Margot struggles.

MORGAN

God said bag the nag, marmite slag.

MARGOT

I'll keep you the cum; harbor you
the ...

MORGAN

(interrupting)
... herkyjerky.

DOUG

Please, within thine own bud
buriest thy content.

MARGOT

Shakespeare-ass.

MORGAN

Spare the bard, Doug.

DOUG

We would all do well to spare our
tongues, as your mother bid.

MARGOT

Cheers to that, wizard.

Everyone looks ahead. Doug suddenly looks dizzy, frantic.

DOUG

Speak ... and I will listen ...

Pebbles appears next to the sense-dep chamber.

BEGIN DOUG'S VISION

EXT. CATHEDRAL - DAY

DOUG (V.O.)

Unheard ... but understood ...

EXT. ESTATE (KISSIMMEE PRAIRIE) - DAY

In the distance lies the French Baroque estate.

DOUG (V.O.)
Speak ... and I will listen ...

EXT. ESTATE / RILKE'S ROOM - DAY

Just outside Rilke's room's window.

DOUG (V.O.)
Unheard ... but understood ...

Inside the window Rilke lies dead in a pool of blood.

END DOUG'S VISION

BACK TO CATHEDRAL

Pebbles is gone. Doug is shaking. Gunther massages Doug's shoulders from behind.

GUNTHER
Meine Maus, are you okay?

DOUG
(coming to)
Let us ... spare our tongues.

MORGAN
Goddamn, wizard.

MARGOT
Shakespeare. Shakes ... fear ...

A generic PRIEST walks up to the altar, coughs, and looks at the family.

PRIEST
(assertively)
Let us bless the body of this
baroness ...

INT. ESTATE / BALLROOM - NIGHT

People in funeral attire mill about in a regal, gold-filled ballroom with tall windows; waiters carry hors-d'oeuvres.

Doug, Morgan, and Margot sit at a prominent table. Rilke snores next to a bowl filled with chewed up t-bones.

DOUG

Margot, your behavior at the service was extremely disrespectful to your mother's profound legacy, even to Rilke.

MARGOT

Narc-ass wizard we got. I hope the will spits you out.

MORGAN

Doug, you should mind the dog; narc on someone your own brainsize.

Doug looks away, petting Rilke.

CASTOR TRUSS, 20s, a slick female lawyer, walks up to their table and extends a hand to Morgan, which Morgan accepts.

TRUSS

Mr. Ehrlich, I'm Castor Truss, from the Law Offices of "Truss & Sons of Truss". I'm sorry for your loss.

MORGAN

My eyes have grown dim with grief.

MARGOT

(to herself)

Some glasses ever darkly be.

TRUSS

Well, I was hoping to speak with you a moment, about final affairs, and such. Normally, I would delay such things, but circumstances, as it were, require ...

Morgan hands his cup to Margot.

MORGAN

(to Margot)

Here, take my cup.

(to Truss)

Ms. Truss, of course. To my humble office.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

The estate office is an exact replica of Morgan's London office: the desk, sense-dep chamber, etc. To-scale photo replicas of the London office view cover all four walls.

Morgan sits at a cluttered desk, flipping through some legal documents. Truss sits across from him.

TRUSS

Of course this means that you and Margot will have only indirect access to the estate's funds, pending approval by either me as executor or, again, Mr. Doug Fennel, as steward.

MORGAN

Yes, I understand. I couldn't imagine it any other way.

TRUSS

Let me know if you need anything else in this matter.

Truss exits the room. Morgan gets on the phone.

MORGAN

Stinger, I need you to get Bergen to stall the Saudi deal ... No, I know ... Look, the expected trove has been plundered ... To the dog ... Yes, everything to the mutt ... No, it's water-tight, legally glued up, that dematrimonied merry matron of mine, mortua est ... Yes, that's right, Stinger. The old bag did bag up our whole bag ... No, we can't slide it from the Dublin account ... nor the Fiji account ...

Morgan pauses, frustrated.

MORGAN

Just tell them it's the supply chain for now. Huge problems with the supply chain; supply chain is glued up. I'll call you when I get something sorted.

Morgan hangs up and bangs his fist once, hard, on the desk.

MORGAN

Goddamn narc-ass wizard bullshit.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Margot sits alone spooning Vegemite from the jar. Rilke slowly walks past her. Rilke whimpers.

INT. ESTATE / DOUG'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Doug and Gunther lie in bed together. A nightstand bears a beat up copy of "Sonnets of Shakespeare".

Three pictures hang on one wall each: 1) Doug with Rilke; 2) Doug's former alligator, Pebbles; 3) boiler-plate photo of Shakespeare. On the fourth wall is a closet, in which sits a box labeled "pet stuff", along with Doug's hanging clothes.

GUNTHER

Is everything alright with you, my
pet, meine kleine Maus?

DOUG

(stand-offish)

Yes.

GUNTHER

Meine süße kleine Maus ... you
refuse to trust your Gunther ...

DOUG

I saw something ... I can't speak
it ... can hardly describe it ...

GUNTHER

Your visions ...

DOUG

Yes.

GUNTHER

A bad one.

DOUG

Yes.

GUNTHER

Mäuschen, what we see is often
mangled ...

DOUG

(interrupting)

It's not like that.

GUNTHER

... mangled by our own ... wie sagt
man ... horn-skin.

DOUG

What?

GUNTHER
You know, that thin layer at the
front of the eye.

DOUG
The eyelid?

GUNTHER
No, the uh ...

DOUG
The cornea?

GUNTHER
Ah, yes, that's the one.

DOUG
Sometimes what we see is mangled by
our own cornea?

GUNTHER
Yes ... yes ...

DOUG
I love you Gunther-guss, but ...

GUNTHER
(interrupting)
You should rest. Put this out of
your brain. Morgen, er, tomorrow,
will be better.

Doug holds back dissent.

GUNTHER
Shall we do our verses tonight,
meine Maus?

DOUG
Of course.

Gunther grabs the "Sonnets of Shakespeare".

GUNTHER
Let me not to the marriage of true
minds / Admit impediments; love is
not love / Which alters when it
alteration finds, / Or bends with
the remover to remove ...

Doug nods off. Gunther finishes the poem to himself and turns
off the light.

INT. ESTATE / SALON - NIGHT

A classic French salon. 18-19th century paintings of animals line the walls. Rilke lies alone on a chaise longue.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "Six Months After the Death of the Baroness"

EXT. PAWS 4 PEOPLE (ORLANDO) - DAY

Morgan stands behind a "Grand Opening" ribbon, holding clown-sized scissors. Rilke sits next to him, and Doug stands next to Rilke.

Behind them, on the building, hangs a "Paws 4 People" drapery. A small audience attends.

MORGAN

While still do we today grieve the late baroness, my dear mother, so too does today mark a new chapter for the people of Orlando. Teaming with Florida Families Family, Paws 4 People will offer daily therapy animals for the disaffected among us: the tired, the abused, the shunted out. These animals are armed with love and are dangerous to despair. Our cynosure, as-and-for-ever, is the Ehrlich family's own doggy-tailed Rilke Wolfmann Ehrlich IV.

DOUG

(to himself)

We are his, not he ours.

MORGAN

(smirking)

Thank you all for joining us below these inclement skies ... may we see, by this, good clemency rise.

The audience applauds.

INT. PAWS 4 PEOPLE - DAY

A charity with a handful of kids and animals milling about. Morgan pets Rilke while talking to CHARITA, the director of the charity, an older woman with flowers in her hair.

Elsewhere, JERRY, about 10, a rambunctious, little boy, pets a random dog. Doug approaches them.

DOUG
Do you like dogs, little boy?

JERRY
My name is Jerry.

DOUG
Little Jerry, do you like dogs?

JERRY
I like cats.

DOUG
I like cats, too. I'll see if we can get some here.

JERRY
Thank you, weird guy.

DOUG
(smiling)
Little Jerry.

Doug walks over to Morgan and Charita.

DOUG
(to Morgan)
You're not petting him correctly.

MORGAN
What are you talking about, Mister Doug?

DOUG
His fur will mat if you scritch him like that.

CHARITA
He looks like he likes it.

DOUG
This fur has remained unmatted for generations.

MORGAN
And eons on ...

DOUG
He doesn't like it.

Morgan crosses his arms.

MORGAN

What do you want, Mister Mister
Doug?

DOUG

We need to provide some cats here.

MORGAN

Meow!

CHARITA

Meow!

DOUG

Little Jerry, nor others, shouldn't
go without feline companionship.

MORGAN

Again, what are you talking about?

CHARITA

I think he's referring to Jerry
over there. He's been in and out of
homes for a while now. Sweet boy.

MORGAN

Regardless of "Little Jerry", you
know I have, in fact, been trying
to wrangle some cats.

DOUG

I can take over some of the charity
accounts, if you think you're too
busy to get stuff done ...

MORGAN

(cutting him off)

We're working on it, Doug-o-tron.

DOUG

The requirements for Rilke's
inheritance of the estate were not
ambiguous. It's well within my
rights to arrest their execution
from you.

MORGAN

Jesus Christ, wizard; unlike you,
we can't just pull cats out of a
bag and turn over the kingdom to
them.

DOUG
(sternly)
Maybe it's better that men be ruled
by felines, after all.

CHARITA
Meow!

INT. MORGAN'S LIMO - NIGHT - TRAVELING

Doug and Rilke sit opposite Morgan in a classic stretch limo.

DOUG
You really embarrassed us today,
Rilke especially.

Morgan looks out the window.

DOUG
Rilke especially.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Morgan is on the phone with Stinger.

MORGAN
Have Bergen tell our peninsular
friends that they'll suffer zero
losses ... No, still no. I will
reckon a way to slack our dear
nanny dog-keeper's leash on the
doggy bag.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Margot has arranged various peeled oranges on the counter and
is taking pictures of them with a large camera.

Doug enters the kitchen with concern.

DOUG
Could you clip Rilke's toenails?

MARGOT
Isn't that your job, squire.

DOUG
Though with all my heart I would,
he prefers when you do it. Hands
more lithe.

MARGOT

Doug-o speaking doggo again.

DOUG

Merely understanding ...

MARGOT

Woof.

DOUG

They'll grow in ingrown if they're not clipped.

MARGOT

Can I get an advance on my share of pittance from my dead mother's stipend.

DOUG

What for?

MARGOT

Travel cash. Me and my buds want to take the helicopter down to the glades to snap some gators. You been down there some right?

DOUG

Why do you want to monkey with gators?

MARGOT

Not that it matters to you, but we want to take some pictures of them to fine-tune a CAPTCHA model to recognize distinct organisms. Thought you'd know where the best crocs might crow.

DOUG

Well, I am familiar with certain parts of the Everglades, yes. I hesitate to send you there, however ... for your safety ...

MARGOT

Oh, don't you worry about me, Doug-o-daddio. Just point me direction-wise.

DOUG

I'll make some calls to see who I
might know that's still in the
area. In exchange for the toenails,
of course.

MARGOT

You drive a hard bargain, Doug-o-
deal.

EXT. ESTATE / TENNIS COURT - DAY

A grass court. Gunther lobbs several tennis balls for Rilke to
catch. Doug walks onto the court.

DOUG

How is he doing today?

Rilke and Gunther continue.

GUNTHER

He is fast, but he is distracted.

DOUG

How do you mean?

GUNTHER

Well, he gets to the ball in time,
always, in plenty of time. But then
he'll sometimes miss the ... the
grab, the bite. More than usual
this is happening.

DOUG

How is his poop?

Gunther stops lobbing.

GUNTHER

Hmm, I think they looked good,
healthy, proportioned.

DOUG

Let's take a time out.

Doug walks over to Rilke, looks him over, examines his teeth.

DOUG

(to Rilke)

What is going on, my king?

Rilke shakes himself.

DOUG
(to Gunther)
Keep an eye on it, will you?

GUNTHER
Natürlich, meine Maus, natürlich.

Doug walks off toward the gardens.

EXT. ESTATE / GARDEN - DAY

Doug enters the well-manicured French garden and looks around concernedly.

A GROUNDSMAN is trimming bushes in the distance. Doug falls over onto his knees.

DOUG
Speak ... and I will listen ...

Pebbles briefly appears next to Doug on the ground.

BEGIN DOUG'S VISION

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Doug stands alone in Morgan's estate office. Suddenly, Rilke, soaking wet, jumps out of the sensory deprivation chamber and disappears through the fake London skyline.

Doug approaches the chamber and sees a dark liquid inside. Doug dips in and pulls out his hands, covered in dark blood.

Doug puts his hands to his face and screams.

END DOUG'S VISION

BACK TO GARDEN

Doug writhes on the ground screaming. The groundskeeper runs over to him.

GROUNDKEEPER
Doug! Doug! Gunther?!

Gunther and Rilke run to Doug. Gunther and the Groundskeeper pick up Doug and carry him toward the house.

INT. ESTATE / DOUG'S BEDROOM - DAY

Doug lies in bed while Gunther stands over him.

GUNTHER
Meine kleine Maus ... you had an
attack ...

DOUG
Another vision ...

GUNTHER
Mäuschen, Mäuschen ...

DOUG
(cutting him off)
Rilke is trying to tell me
something. Something is happening
... is going to happen ...

GUNTHER
(sighing)
Meine süße Liebe ...

DOUG
I'm sorry, Gunther-guss. I just ...
feel ... I know ...

GUNTHER
(cutting him off)
Okay ... just get some rest.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Margot is comparing the pictures of oranges she had
previously taken: some on her computer, some printed out.
Doug walks in.

MARGOT
What's the word on the glades,
wizard.

DOUG
The place I know has some rooms
open. It used to be pretty run
down, but it looks like they've got
... new management since I was
there.

MARGOT
Got good gators right round?

DOUG

Yes, there should be some gator spots ... to view from afar, of course. I wouldn't want to risk Rilke losing a sibling ...

MARGOT

We want to bask in the glow of their teeth.

DOUG

... because, as you may know, Rilke has been wanting to see some new scenery, too.

MARGOT

Extra extra: Victorian Scrooge McDog's pedigree cut short when New World croc's denture punctures the recent inheritor's glinting coat.

DOUG

God forbid, Margot. Still, your allowance would be fronted in exchange for allowing Rilke onboard. And have you clipped his toenails yet?

MARGOT

Fine: clip'im and bring'im. Prairie-dog-ass mutt. Dig-a-hole-ass-scared-of-gators-ass mutt.

DOUG

Or you could clip him and stay here; leave the asshole out of it. Regardless, I'll be attending him.

MARGOT

Gatorade!

INT. GOON'S STORE - DAY

Margot enters the store; no one else is inside.

MARGOT

Yo, losers! ... Worm!? ... Snake!?

Margot walks to the back and through an obscure door.

INT. GOON'S LAB - DAY

In back of the store front. A poorly lit laboratory with electronics scattered about.

Worm runs on a strange, triangular treadmill. Snake operates a computer monitoring Worm's heart rate and other vitals.

Margot walks in.

MARGOT

Sup, loser-trons. We're on for the glades. You finish the heat map for our marshy romp?

SNAKE

Not yet, Corleone.

MARGOT

Get on it.

WORM

Busy, Corleoney.

SNAKE

(to Worm)

How much longer you want to go?

WORM

Until I can go no longer.

The electricity in the lab sparks out. The lab goes dark. Worm trips and his head hits part of the treadmill with a thump.

INT. ESTATE / SALON - NIGHT

Margot sits on the non-backrest side of the chaise longue, with Rilke on the floor in front of her. She clips his nails.

A large camera sits on a table, circuits showing, connected to a laptop. A map of the Everglades is in front of her.

Doug walks in.

DOUG

You're doing it wrong.

MARGOT

The fuck are you talking about.

DOUG
You have to turn it other way.
You're doing it upside down.

MARGOT
You're trying to make nail clipping
into nerdshit.

Doug walks over and takes the clippers, turns them over, and hands them back. Margot turns them back to how she had them.

DOUG
Margot, this is absurd.

He takes them again, turns them over, and hands them back. Margot again turns them back to how she had them. Doug lightly slaps Margot on the face.

MARGOT
What the fuck Doug-dingus. Clipping
me ... for clipper clamping.

Doug looks taken aback but doubles down.

DOUG
Your job, at least as it pertains
to Rilke, is to do what I say.
That's how it is; it's the law.

MARGOT
Go clip yourself: nails are done.

Doug walks out with Rilke. Margot arranges her map.

EXT. ESTATE / PATIO - DAY

Helicopter landing pad in view.

Margot, Snake, and Worm review a map on a patio table. Large gear packs sit nearby them on the ground.

Doug arrives from the house with Rilke, who is wearing some kind of dog safety vest. Doug wears a backpack.

DOUG
Rilke is all set for our little
romp.

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
We'll go to go get set, too.

Doug and Worm leave with the packs of gear.

DOUG

We'll land at a campsite. I'd recommend not straying too far from the cabin.

MARGOT

Alright, Doug-o-dad-bod.

DOUG

I'm serious.

MARGOT

You know me: Madam Careful. Madam sweet baby Careful. Many polloi will approach unto me saying, "Look, there is Madam Careful, the carefullest madam of them all; look at her being quite so careful, careful in a careful manner and much more careful than any mortal has a right to be careful." People say that to me.

DOUG

Alright, Margot.

MARGOT

"Oh how she tips and toes, each step perfectly careful ... "

DOUG

(interrupting)
Alright.

Worm and Snake return wearing grass/moss camouflage suits.

MARGOT

Now that's what I call careful.

Worm and Snake salute Margot.

WORM AND SNAKE

(together)

At your service, Madam Careful.

SNAKE

(to Doug)

You know, Dougy ... we are currently pulling an American: jump-starting a second business.

WORM

(to Doug)

Family-owned.

SNAKE

You ever need anything: you let us
know, okay, Bob?

Snake pulls from his suit somewhere a stack of business
cards. He hands one to Doug.

INSERT - THE BUSINESS CARD

"Nice Goons Inc.: We help you do stuff, legally. Contact:
nicegoons.info/help"

BACK TO SCENE

WORM

Tell your friends.

MARGOT

Alright, criminals, let's go.

The helicopter lands; they get in. The helicopter takes off.

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / CABIN - DAY

The helicopter arrives at a marshy Everglades campground
called "Gibble's Gambol", located somewhere north of
Everglades City, near the border between wet prairie and
cypress groves. Some fan boats sit in nearby water.

An old Florida man, GIBBLE, wearing a straw hat and smoking,
watches from a cabin.

Rilke jumps out once the helicopter is grounded and shutting
down. Everyone else jumps out and walks towards the cabin.

GIBBLE

(straight-faced)

What's up, Doug?

Doug is taken aback. He grimaces.

DOUG

Gibble, I didn't realize you'd be
here ... I thought the place was
... sold ... new owners ...

GIBBLE

Well, it's true that I sold the
place. But man does not live on
bread alone.

DOUG
 Of course ...
 (to Margot)
 I think maybe our welcome might be
 less than given.

GIBBLE
 Nonsense. You're more than welcome,
 for old times' sake.

MARGOT
 Chill out, Doug-dingus. Besides,
 we're already here. I'm sure it's
 fine.

DOUG
 Margot, I really don't feel
 comfortable ...

GIBBLE
 (interrupting)
 What do you say, Margot?

MARGOT
 A real bucolic paradise you got
 here, Gibble. Worth exploring, I'd
 say.

DOUG
 Margot, you don't understand ...

MARGOT
 (interrupting)
 Look how happy the dog is, Doug. He
 can't get enough swamp to save his
 life.

Doug looks at Rilke. Rilke watches some birds with interest.

DOUG
 This okay, Rilke? You like it here?

Rilke runs off toward a bird.

DOUG
 Fine, we'll stay.

GIBBLE
 It's settled then. Who're these
 studded lugs?

Worm and Snake lurch into shaking hands with Gibble, handing
 him some business cards.

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
We're your new best friends.

GIBBLE
I reckon so.

WORM
I'm Snake.

SNAKE
The hell. I'm Snake.

WORM
Ah, oops, yes ... yes, and I'm
Snake.

SNAKE
Goddamnit, Worm.

WORM
(bewildered, to himself)
What the fuck ...

GIBBLE
(to Doug)
Good-lookin' dog. Dog got stamina?

Margot looks skeptical at Gible. The goons space off.

DOUG
Knock it off, Gible.

GIBBLE
Alright! I'll show you all to your
quarters now.

WORM
(to Gible)
Thanks, Snake!

INT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / CABIN - DAY

Everyone enters the cabin, which comprises two floors. The ground floor is a saloon-like restaurant. On the walls are a bunch of pictures of alligators in the Everglades. Stairs lead to the bedrooms.

GIBBLE
Well, I only had two rooms for the
lot of ya. You can split as you
will.

(MORE)

GIBBLE (CONT'D)
 Just go up these stairs here, and
 the first two rooms on the right
 are yours.

Gibble hands Doug and Margot keys.

DOUG
 Rilke and I will take one room.
 These three can take the other.

GIBBLE
 I'll rummage a cot out the shed.

MARGOT
 Snake, Worm, go snag the bigger of
 the rooms. And bring me my rubber
 bottoms.

WORM AND SNAKE
 (together)
 Alright, Madam Carcass.

Worm and Snake go upstairs with all the bags.

MARGOT
 My friend, Gibs. You know where
 good gators go?

GIBBLE
 I'm an ancient gator man, knows
 where all the gators gambol ...

DOUG
 (cutting him off)
 Margot, we talked about this ...
 Gibble, really, let's not ...

MARGOT
 Dog's staying parked with you,
 Doug-god. We'll be fine, won't we,
 Mr. Gibs?

GIBBLE
 I reckon so, on account of your
 clearly keenly wits.

MARGOT
 See, Dougy. My clearly keenly wits
 will keep me kindly. Now, Gibs,
 about those gambols ...

GIBBLE
 I'll get'chu a map.

MARGOT
(to Gibble)
I'll booze up and lie in wait.

Margot goes to the bar.

DOUG
Old dogs, old tricks, Gibs.

GIBBLE
Distrustful Doug. What am I if not
ingratiating. She'll keep her wits.

DOUG
If you say so.

GIBBLE
She'll keep her skin, as well.

DOUG
(perturbed)
And our other mutual friend?

GIBBLE
Heart attack, Doug. I wept for
days, deeply moved in spirit,
greatly distressed ...

DOUG
Fine. That path around the south
still good and clear?

GIBBLE
No pitfalls along the gambol. Paved
now. Walked it myself just this
morn. A favorite of the yellower
tourists. You one of them, Dougs?

DOUG
Yes, I am. Besides, Rilke, here, is
my life's work now, is my life. My
yellow life.

GIBBLE
(chuckling)
Alright!

EXT. CYPRESS GROVES - DAY

Worm, Snake, and Margot ride a fan boat slowly through a
cypress grove. Worm and Snake wear their grass camo; Margot
wears fly fishing waders.

Margot has a camera with a huge lens and is trying to decipher a map with Gibble's hand-drawn notes.

A distant alligator jumps into the water from the banks.

MARGOT

Fuck we just missed one.

They continue on a bit, but soon the fan stops working.

MARGOT

Garbage-ass. Worm, get on it.

Worm checks out the fan for a bit, then jumps into the water to look at it.

MARGOT

Worm ... why?

WORM

Baby boy needs a cool down.

MARGOT

No he doesn't.

WORM

Yo, unrelatedly, they got that piss-fish in here?

MARGOT

That's why. Ferus est iste.

SNAKE

You're pissing?

WORM

Just saying, if I were to piss ...

SNAKE

What the fuck is a piss-fish?

MARGOT

I think he means the Candiru.

WORM

What's the Candiru?

MARGOT

It's a fish that's supposedly attracted to urine and can follow the yellow stream into human holes. Not well-verified. It only lives in the Amazon.

WORM

Margot "Steve Attenborough" Irwin.

SNAKE

You're wearing waterproof pants.
The fuck you even worried about
your hole for?

WORM

One time I was just basking in a
lake, and a fish bit me on the
nipple.

SNAKE

Was your nipple wearing waterproof
pants?

WORM

Look, it drew blood, okay?

SNAKE

You just pissed. I somehow smell
it.

WORM

Candiru-ass goon. Don't go snooping
around my little hole.

MARGOT

Both of you just shut the fuck up.
Worm what's the status?

WORM

Junky water-jitney's jilted.

MARGOT

Fine, we'll take turns rowing.

Worm gets back in the boat. Snake pulls out two oars and
starts rowing.

MARGOT

This will be quieter, anyway. Just
keep your eyes peeled for nostrils.
We need enough pictures of someone
near enough to a gator both for
training data and for test data.

WORM

This idea is harebrained as hell.

SNAKE

It was your idea.

WORM
The fuck it was!

SNAKE
You said, we needed to fix our
CAPTCHA shit because it was, quote,
"goofing up on animals".

WORM
Yeah, but I said we should use
petite-ass squirrels, not actual-
ass alligators.

They look at Margot.

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
Margot, what the fuck.

Snake gives the oars to Margot.

MARGOT
Shut up. I thought this would be
more awesome. Whatever, just keep
watching. I think I see a little
caiman up ahead.

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
Caimans count.

Margot continues rowing.

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / THE GAMBOL - DAY

Doug and Rilke stroll about a nice, paved path around a
marsh, the cabin in view.

Other visitors also walk by, taking in the sights. Doug will
periodically say "hi" to those passing by.

Rilke sniffs various plants and patches of water.

DOUG
Rilke, this day is just balmy
enough. Bawdy, even. Beautiful.

Rilke barks in assent.

DOUG
I'm sorry we haven't had a chance
to talk after your mother's death,
with all the commotion.
(MORE)

DOUG (CONT'D)
 "Had we but world enough and time
 ... ". You do prefer Marvell to
 Shakespeare. How are you holding
 up?

Rilke remains silent.

DOUG
 I know it's been tough. You miss
 the baroness ...

They stop at a bench. Doug sits.

DOUG
 "We would sit down, and think which
 way to walk, and pass our long
 love's day."

Rilke goes off to romp in a patch of tall grass.

DOUG
 Speak ... and I will listen ...

Doug's eyes roll back and his head falls back onto the bench.
 Pebbles briefly appears on the walking path.

BEGIN DOUG'S VISION

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

COLIN MOCHRIE, the actor, covered in blood, is shown weeping
 over Rilke's dead, bloody body.

MOCHRIE
 What have we done?

Rilke, still wounded, sits up and looks directly at the
 camera. RILKE'S VOICE, a deep, calm voice speaks.

RILKE'S VOICE (V.O.)
 Doug, it's time to fulfill your
 filial duty to my lineage.

DOUG (V.O.)
 I know, I know. I've been trying.
 The children ... they keep getting
 in the way ... They're
 uncooperative ...

Colin Mochrie looks directly at the camera.

MOCHRIE

Doug, it's time to fulfill your
filial duty to Rilke's lineage.

DOUG (V.O.)

I will. I must. Is something going
to happen to Rilke? Rilke, what's
going to happen to you?

EXT. CITRUS FARM / ORCHARD - DAY

Rows and rows of well-manicured citrus trees. Rilke tends to
several German Shepherd pups with a female German Shepherd.

RILKE'S VOICE (V.O.)

From fairest creatures we desire
increase,/ That thereby beauty's
rose might never die,/ But as the
riper should by time decease,/ His
tender heir might bear his memory;/
But thou, contracted to thine own
bright eyes,/ Feed'st thy light's
flame with self-substantial fuel,/
Making a famine where abundance
lies,/ Thyself thy foe, to thy
sweet self too cruel./ Thou that
art now the world's fresh ornament/
And only herald to the gaudy
spring,/ Within thine own bud
buriest thy content,/ And, tender
churl, mak'st waste in niggarding./
Pity the world, or else this
glutton be,/ To eat the world's
due, by the grave and thee.

DOUG (V.O.)

I understand. I understand ...

END DOUG'S VISION

BACK TO THE GAMBOL

Doug convulses on the bench while people stare. Rilke runs up
to him and gently licks his hand.

Gibble runs to him along the path.

GIBBLE

Doug, what on earth. Doug!

Doug comes to and looks at Gibble.

DOUG

I know why this keeps happening ...
I'm okay, I'm okay. I move with a
purpose.

GIBBLE

It's okay, people. I know this man;
he's just possessed. I'm an
ordained man!

Gibble helps Doug walk toward the cabin. Rilke follows.

EXT. CYPRESS GROVES - DAY

Margot rows the boat while Worm and Snake eat hard-boiled
eggs. The camera is on a tripod in the center of the boat.

In the distance is what appears to be two alligators.

MARGOT

(whispering)

Alright you brutes be quiet. I see
a pair of scalies.

They slowly approach the gators to discover that they are
stuffed and attached to the left and right front sides of
another, larger air boat.

GABLE, an old, leather-skinned Florida man, wearing only cut-
off jeans, reclines on the boat.

MARGOT

(whispering)

There came up out of the river a
cow, poor and very ill favoured and
leanfleshed, such as I never saw in
all the land of Egypt for badness.

SNAKE

Man looking as a dried apricot.

WORM

Man looking as ... a dead apricot.

GABLE

(eyes closed)

You ain't in Egypt no more,
ladygirls.

Margot and the goons look at each other.

MARGOT

Reeds not unlike the Nile's.

Gable sits up and opens his eyes.

GABLE

The pharaoh be cuter, though. That I am, that I am. Don'tchu think so?

MARGOT

Can't say I'm familiar with the pharaoh's physiognomy, waterman. Though you both reflect a certain likeness to the sun, I suppose.

GABLE

Perhaps. Or, Pharaoh phy-si-og-no-mi-ni-ous.

MARGOT

Think you could divine-right us toward some gators, waterman. Gatorman. Or are they sturgeon.

GABLE

I might could. They ain't royal, but they is guarded. VIP only. You slipped a gun under that lens?

Worm and Snake go back to eating eggs.

MARGOT

No sir, we're just shooting pictures. Gible sent us down this way.

GABLE

Gible! Now that's a sweet relation of mine, a cousin. If he sentchu, I'll sentchu farther.

WORM AND SNAKE

(together)

Gible.

GABLE

Now look see, on Gible's honor ... you interested in some real gatorly VIP access tonight?

MARGOT

I'm not disrobing if that's what you mean.

GABLE

I didn't mean a goddamn thing of the sort. I'm talking about a scene worth seeing.

WORM

(to himself)

I love me a little local flavor.

GABLE

(to Worm)

Now that's the spirit.

MARGOT

Alright, gatorman, we'll bite.

GABLE

Good. It ain't far from here. I'll fix yer map with the spot.

Margot hands Gable her map.

GABLE

I think I got just what you need for that there fan, too.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - DAY

Morgan sits at his desk on the phone.

MORGAN

Hi is this Cat Cave? ... Great, look, I run a charity that hosts therapy pets for the under-privileged ... yes, that's right, "Paws 4 People", you've heard of it ... Listen, we've got a lot of canines right now, but I'm wondering if you had any felines you think would fit ... No, not to borrow ...

Morgan sighs, annoyed.

MORGAN

Yes, we would pay handsomely ...
Yes, we can list you as a partner ... Great, I'll stop by this week ... thank you.

Morgan hangs up, and looks at the wall, tired. He gets up and pulls out from a cabinet a box with family photos, camera tapes, and an old camcorder.

He returns to his desk, opens the box, and picks out a photo and stares at it: the baroness, noticeably happy, sits next to a German Shepherd.

Morgan puts it away, aggrieved. He fully undresses and gets into the sense-dep chamber.

INT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / DOUG'S ROOM - NIGHT

Doug lies in bed, clothed. Gibble is getting dressed, starting at just his underwear. Rilke sleeps in a tent.

GIBBLE

Thanks, sweets. Been a while. You going to be ok?

DOUG

Yes ... a while. I'll be fine.

Gibble leaves. Doug pulls out his phone and dials.

DOUG

Hello? Hi this is Doug Fennel, with Rilke, the German Shepherd. You still have that German Shepherd bitch ... You do? ... That's great. Would you mind if I stop by next week sometime?

EXT. ORTHODONTIST II (CYPRESS GROVE) - NIGHT

Margot, Worm, and Snake, still in their boat, the fan working, approach a large, decrepit-seeming paddle steamer, "The Orthodontist II", tucked away in a cypress grove.

The steamer has two visible levels: the bottom (1st) is enclosed with large windows, and the top (2nd) is open-air. People are dancing to electronica on the top level.

SNAKE

Local-ass flavor.

WORM

Forgot to floss again ...

MARGOT

Y'all keep your pockets zipped-ass.

Worm and Snake literally zip their pockets. Their boat comes upon a side ladder that leads up to the top of the boat. Other fan boats are anchored nearby.

All three start to climb it. Margot takes their camera.

EXT. ORTHODONTIST II / LEVEL 2 - NIGHT

Margot, Snake, and Worm fight their way through a rave. On one side an old, scrubby DJ sways gratuitously with the music.

Behind the DJ is an LED "Leader Board", which comprises a ranked list of odd names.

INSERT - THE LIST OF NAMES

1. Snackhead - 2. Sharper - 3. Cryptoff - 4. Bryan's
5. Friendster - 6. Regretto - 7. Stabilitron - 8. Golfman

BACK TO SCENE

Some dancers try to give them ecstasy. Worm accepts some, but Margot smacks it out of his hand.

They notice some small caimans running around, with glow-ring bracelets muzzling their snouts.

On the opposite side as the DJ, they come upon and descend a stairs leading down to level 1.

INT. ORTHODONTIST II / LEVEL 1 - NIGHT

The three exit the stairs next to a bar and bartender.

On the wall behind the bartender is one framed photo.

INSERT - THE PHOTO

A younger Gable smiles in front of a boat called "The Orthodontist" with a "Grand Opening" banner. This boat is similar to but smaller than The Orthodontist II.

BACK TO SCENE

A fully operating casino: people play cards, roulette, etc. The guests are a mix of upper-class (well-dressed) and lower-class (scrubby-dressed), men and women of each class.

Something loud is going on beneath them: thumping, cheering, floor shaking.

Gable, in the same garb as before, plays poker at one of the tables and calls over to them.

GABLE
My gentle Potiphar!

MARGOT
This a river of blood, Tutankhamen?

GABLE
Sometimes, sometimes ... you callin
me young, sweet one?

WORM
(vaguely Seinfeldish)
What's the deal ... with this boat?

GABLE
Y'all got cash, ain't ye?

Worm nods, reaching for his breast pocket. Snake slaps the
top of Worm's head. Gable laughs.

GABLE
(to Worm)
Deal's what you make it.

MARGOT
Whatever, pigskin. You mind if we
poke around a bit? What's
downstairs? We're not big on
glowsticks, nor dice.

GABLE
Now that ... that's exclusive-like
... very V-I-P.

WORM
(whispering)
Very Virtual Internet Protocol.

MARGOT
Suppose I empty my goon here's
pocket on a certain someone that
goes by Mr. Cryptoff.

GABLE
Boy's been boxxed out, I'm afraid.

MARGOT
Stabilitron.

GABLE
Mighty fine boy.
(to Worm)
How heavy that pocket be, Mr. Goon?

Worm looks around the room. Snake slaps the top of his head.

WORM

Oh, right. Hmm, about 16 grams, Mr. Pharaoh?

MARGOT

Worm ... the fuck ...

WORM

LMAO ... 10 twenties is 10 grams, plus 6 fifties is another 6 grams.

SNAKE

500 smackers, pigskin.

Gable gives Snake a patronizing look.

GABLE

Mighty fine price for a mighty fine boy.

Gable whistles a unique sequence of notes, and NEPHEW, a boy of around 10 years old in ragged clothes, crawls out from under the bar and approaches Gable.

NEPHEW

Yes, uncle?

GABLE

You think you can lift up to 16 grams, boy?

NEPHEW

I reckon not, uncle. Sounds burdensome.

GABLE

Very good. All the same, have the captain smack this smackhead goon's green smackers on Stabilitron.

NEPHEW

Yes, uncle.

Nephew goes to a wall opposite the bar. A bouncer comes into view, wearing clothes that camouflage him into the wall.

The bouncer opens a hidden door in the wall, and Nephew descends into it.

GABLE

Alright, sweet ones. Enjoy the show.

Gable gestures them to descend to where his nephew disappeared.

They get to the bouncer, who takes the camera from Margot. The three of them enter the formerly hidden door.

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / MUD BATH - NIGHT

Doug relaxes in a natural mud bath, along with some other guests. Rilke lies outside the mud next to Doug.

DOUG

This sable coat is a dominant gene,
so, I guess, we'll only really have
to worry about your grand-puppies?
Best the bitch's coat be sable,
just in case, though.

Gibble arrives and gets in the mud bath.

INT. ORTHODONTIST II / BELOW DECK - NIGHT

Margot, Worm, Snake descend a dusty staircase, distantly following Gable's nephew. Yelling gets increasingly loud.

The three come upon a sweaty, rowdy crowd surrounding a walled-off area in the center. On opposite sides of the walled area are two smaller, walled off "vestibules", such that there is no access from them into the ring or into the crowd.

Inside each vestibule is an adult alligator. On one of the walls is an electric scoreboard sign that reads "Stabilitron v. Regretto".

The three work their way through the crowd.

A bell goes off, and two men near but outside the vestibules turn two large wheels, causing doors, that lead from the vestibules into the ring, to open.

The two alligators move quickly toward each other and fight.

MARGOT

This is much stupider than I
expected. Whatever. Worm, get some
pics while we're at it.

Worm pulls a disposable polaroid camera out of his pocket and proceeds to take pictures of the fight.

After a few camera flashes, a large man appears from behind Worm and snatches the camera aggressively. The man leaves without a word. Worm is bewildered.

Back in the ring, one of the alligators goes limp, bloody. "Regretto wins" flashes on the screen.

Some of the crowd moves to a betting booth. Margot, Worm, Snake go check out the ring as workers clean it.

MARGOT

Alright. I think we've done enough here. Fucking stinks in here.

The three of them work their way back through the crowd to the stairs and head back up.

INT. ORTHODONTIST II / LEVEL 1 - NIGHT

Margot, Worm, Snake get to the casino area. Gable is gone. Nephew sees and approaches them.

NEPHEW

My uncle had other matters to attend to. He says "my regrets that your boy was fated to fumble this round". He hopes you return. Here's a map for the boat's next location.

Nephew hands Margot an envelope and keeps his hand held for a tip. Worm pulls out a smushed egg and gives it to him.

Margot puts the envelope into her pocket. She gets her camera from Gable's former table. The three move toward and up the other stairs.

EXT. ORTHODONTIST II / LEVEL 2 - NIGHT

The three move through the rave, which is still going strong. They descend the ladder.

EXT. ORTHODONTIST II - NIGHT

They get into their fan boat. A small caiman is inside the boat, resting. Upon their entering it wakes up and hisses.

MARGOT

Worm, deal with this.

WORM

Right away, Madam Careful.

Worm tackles and bags the caiman, and he puts the bag aside in the boat. They start the boat and head down the water.

Margot pulls out the envelope from her pocket. Inside the envelope is a newspaper clipping, which Margot looks at briefly, skeptically, and then replaces in her pocket.

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / MUD BATH - NIGHT

Gibble and Doug are chatting.

Rilke lies nearby, out of the mud, sleeping under a towel.

GIBBLE
Mud feel like it always did do, ol'
Doug, sweets?

Doug puts his head back and closes his eyes.

DOUG
Something like it.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "Ten Years and Six Months Before the Death of the Baroness"

BEGIN FLASHBACK

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / MUD BATH - NIGHT

Younger Doug rests in the same spot in the mud bath.

Instead of Rilke, there's Pebbles, with its collar and ring on, sleeping under a towel. His metal ring is prominently placed around one of the alligator's front fingers.

They relax together until Doug, wearing a swimsuit, gets out and pets Pebbles, waking it up.

DOUG
Pebbles, my sweet one, time to go.

Doug attaches a leash to the collar and they rinse themselves with a nearby hose.

INT. GROCERY STORE (EVERGLADES CITY) - DAY

Doug walks Pebbles around a small grocery store. He stops to pick out some meat.

JACKY, a child around 8, approaches them.

JACKY
Hello. Can I touch yer gator?

DOUG
Absolutely, little boy. He's quite friendly.

Jacky crouches and pets the gator.

JACKY's MOTHER quickly approaches them and screams.

JACKY'S MOTHER
Jacky, get the hell away from that gator!

JACKY
Ma! He's quite friendly!

Jacky's Mother grabs Jacky by the hand. Pebbles snorts as they walk away.

JACKY
Only in Florida ...

EXT. ORTHODONTIST (EVERGLADES) - DAY

The Orthodontist, the boat from the photo behind the bar of The Orthodontist II, is located in an Everglades marsh, somewhere near Everglades City. The boat is not fully built.

The area is accessible by car via one dirt road, with enough space for cars to park, but is otherwise surrounded by swamp.

Doug and Gible talk away from the boat. Pebbles is leashed next to Doug. Doug wears a generic shirt and jeans.

Gable talks to some workers by the boat.

GIBBLE
Well, this is it. My dear cousin's floating sanctuary to-be. I'm afraid it's not much to gaze upon.

DOUG
Well "that sweet ornament" which charity gives "more beauteous" makes it seem.

GIBBLE
Alright!

Gable approaches them. Pebbles hisses, and Doug shushes him.

GABLE
Hello, cousin. This that gator-
holding psychic sweetheart?

GIBBLE
The same he be.

Gable and Doug shake hands.

DOUG
Pleasure to meet you.

GABLE
Well, this showboat is almost up
and runnin.

DOUG
Quite quickly so, I hear.

GABLE
Yup, yup, well, when yer ponies
believe in yer gators yer in good
shape. Plus the relative ease of
taxes for floating establishments
and the like.

DOUG
Yes, of course. Well, I'm excited
that someone is finally taking an
honest interest in the well-being
of our alligators.

Gable looks down at Pebbles.

GABLE
This your boy here?

DOUG
Yes, yes. This is my sweet Pebbles.
He's got a good home, mind you.
Good enough, at least, I pray.

GABLE
'Course, 'course. What he thinkin'
at the moment?

DOUG
I'm afraid my access is only
patchily provided me, rather than
an always open door.

GABLE

Sure, sure. Well, I best be back to scrubbin'. Anything you can help with this noble endeavor's much 'ppreciated.

DOUG

Absolutely.

INT. DOUG'S HOUSE (EVERGLADES) - NIGHT

Doug and Pebbles live in a small one-bedroom, detached home. They are on about two acres of property in a small, poor community in a marshy area.

Doug and Pebbles sit on a couch, watching TV: "Whose Line is it Anyway" Season 4 Episode 16, "Questions Only" [the "Bawdy Western"].

Pebbles' head is in Doug's lap. Pebbles croaks.

DOUG

He's not out to get you, sweet one.

Gibble walks in from the kitchen and sits next to Doug, on the opposite side of Pebbles. Gibble starts kissing Doug.

Pebbles gets up and goes into a dog bed on the floor.

EXT. GROCERY STORE - DAY

Doug and Pebbles sit at a folding table near the grocery store entrance.

A sign draped over the table reads "Floating Alligator Rescue: Anything Helps". A jar with some spare change sits on the table.

A CUSTOMER comes up to the table from the parking lot.

CUSTOMER

The fuck is a floating gator rescue?

DOUG

Exactly as it sounds, friend.

They stare at each other. Pebbles makes a croaking sound.

DOUG

Well, we've got a boat on the marsh.

(MORE)

DOUG (CONT'D)
And any alligator, wild or
domestic, that needs rescuing, we
take care of it in the boat.

CUSTOMER
Really stupid stuff.

The customer throws in some change and walks inside.

DOUG
Thank you!

EXT. ORTHODONTIST - DAY

Gibble and Gable talk outside the boat. Others go inside.

Doug and Pebbles walk up to them. Doug pulls a kid's wagon
full of jars that are full of change.

GABLE
Well, looky what we've got here. A
mighty fine donation that be. You
must have buried some coin in the
ground.

GIBBLE
He's got a talent for coin, I do
reckon.

GABLE
Off to the market according to our
own respective talents, I do
reckon.

DOUG
I do what I can.

GABLE
Very good, and we bescaled beings
can't thank you enough.

DOUG
Till your scales turn the beams.

Gable looks at Doug perplexed, displeased.

GABLE
Yes, I s'pose 'til then. Listen: we
still got plenty of slots for this
here friend of yours. Quite comfy
he'll be. We rigged an auto-washer,
conveyor belts, like a carwash,
get'im all polished and all that.

DOUG

Oh, no, no. Pebbles here lives quite well enough with me. I don't know what I'd do without him, honestly. Might I have a look at the fruits of my talent, though? A look inside?

GABLE

Oh, them goin' in? They're workers all. Odds and ends to even, etc. Nails on the floor: not safe for feets. Give it another week, the varnish will be dry, and all that.

DOUG

(disappointed)

Yes, absolutely, of course.

GIBBLE

Well, Doug, we best be letting Gable get back to work.

DOUG

Sure, of course.

Doug and Pebbles walk off.

INT. DOUG'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Doug and Pebbles watch "Whose Line" (any episode).

Smoke enters the room from the kitchen. Doug doesn't notice right away, but Pebbles gets fidgety.

Soon, Doug notices, bolts up, and runs into the kitchen, only to be forced out by a minor explosion.

Pebbles paces on the floor.

DOUG

Pebbles! We gotta get out of here!

Doug leashes Pebbles and brings him outside.

EXT. DOUG'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Doug attaches Pebbles' leash to a branch of a nearby dead tree and pats himself down in search of his phone.

Doug suddenly sprints toward the nearest neighbor's house, which is at least about a half-mile away.

EXT. DOUG'S NEIGHBOR'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Doug knocks frantically on the door until NEIGHBOR comes out.

DOUG
(out of breath)
Hi, I'm sorry. Can you call 911. My
house is on fire.

NEIGHBOR
Oh fuck!

The neighbor goes back into the house. Doug runs back.

EXT. DOUG'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Doug gets to the tree Pebbles was leashed to but only finds there the leash and an empty, dangling collar.

He runs frantically around while shouting for Pebbles.

Eventually, Doug sinks down onto the ground and weeps as the house burns down and firetrucks arrive.

EXT. DOUG'S HOUSE - DAY

Doug wakes up in the same spot.

Some firemen still investigate the remains of the house. One of the firemen calls to him, but Doug ignores him.

Doug gets up, dusts himself off, and runs down the road.

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / CABIN - DAY

Doug arrives at "Gibble's Gambol" on foot where he finds Gibble sitting outside.

GIBBLE
Goddamn, do you look a sight to
see. Man to ashes from ashes.

DOUG
Gibbles, he's gone.

GIBBLE
Excuse me, dustman?

DOUG
Pebbles is gone. I don't know where
he is.

(MORE)

DOUG (CONT'D)
He slipped out of his leash, or something. Maybe he was mad at me. House burned down.

GIBBLE
How the fuck did this happen?

DOUG
I don't know! I must have left the stove on. Fire came from the kitchen. I just don't know.

GIBBLE
Alright, alright. Let's get you down to the police station, so we can get this sorted.

DOUG
Yes, okay, okay. They can help us find him.

EXT. POLICE STATION (EVERGLADES CITY) - DAY

Gibble and Doug arrive at the police station in Gibble's old pickup truck.

GIBBLE
Alright, you go buzz your business. I'll go check with Gable to see if somehow Pebbles wound up at our gator shelter.

DOUG
Thank god for the gator shelter.

Doug runs into the police station and Gibble drives off.

INT. POLICE STATION - DAY

Two police officers, MARLOWE, a middle-aged, slow-talking male, and CRASHAW, a middle-aged, slow-talking female, loaf about bored behind a typical counter. Doug huffs in.

DOUG
Hi, I need to report a missing animal.

MARLOWE
Hear that, Crashaw. The fellow's got a beast amissing.

CRASHAW

Another beast amissing, Marlowe?
Say, Marlowe: how could it that a
fellow might "have" a beast
amissing? Should he have it, it'd
be apresent, and should it be
amissing, he'd have it not.

DOUG

Please, officer, officers. "I do
count the clock that tells the
time" ...

MARLOWE

(interrupting)

I hear your point, Crashaw. So, I
correct myself: there seems to be a
beast amissing, one that pertains,
I suppose, by right, to this fellow
here.

CRASHAW

Pertains, pertains, absolutely. A
mutt I reckon, what that deserves
to be so.

DOUG

No, no ... it's my alligator,
Pebbles.

CRASHAW

A mutt of sorts it be, exotic-like.
Marlowe, get him that form for
exotic mutts.

Marlowe locates a form and hands it to Doug.

INSERT - FORM 1

The top of the form reads "Animal Control Request". The rest
of the page contains fields for information, including "Type
of Animal".

BACK TO SCENE

DOUG

Officers, please. He's my pet. He's
only ever lived with me in a home,
domestic. He won't survive out
there. He's vaccinated and
everything.

MARLOWE

I'm sorry, fellow. That's the only form we have for exotic mutts.

CRASHAW

We only got two forms for mutts, I fear, and that one there is the one for those exotic-like, that one he gave you, in your very hand.

Marlowe locates a different form and hands it to Doug.

INSERT - FORM 2

The top of the form reads "Missing Pet Request". The rest of the page contains fields for information, including three check-boxes for "Dog", "Cat", and "Other".

BACK TO SCENE

MARLOWE

You see, on that form you only got "Dogs" and "Cats". Got no box for "Gator".

Doug looks over the two forms.

DOUG

Can't I use this "Other" box on the "Pets" form?

Marlowe takes the second form from Doug and looks it over.

MARLOWE

Well look here, Crashaw. This form got an "Other" box on it now. "Dog", "Cat", and "Other". Right on it, there.

CRASHAW

Well, I'll be damned, Marlowe. That form's been augmented. Slick off the presses. I printed them this recent morning. Weren't just yesterday that same form was by one box less.

MARLOWE

Just this recent morning. I'll be damned. What an awe-ing augmentation. You go ahead and use this other form, then, fellow. It's your lucky day.

Marlowe hands the form back to Doug.

DOUG
Okay, thank you so much.

Doug starts filling out the form.

CRASHAW
Each day be lucky, or none,
Marlowe. Now, Marlowe, could it be
that the present form augmented
could as the former form
unaugmented called the same be?

MARLOWE
I reckon, without it being the same
of properties, the present form
augmented would only, in a certain
way, pertain to the former form
unaugmented.

CRASHAW
Pertains, pertains, absolutely.

A truck honks from outside the station. Doug looks around and returns to the form.

Gibble enters the police station.

GIBBLE
Doug, we've been played. Utterly,
utterly stinkfished.

MARLOWE
Crashaw, look what the mutt dragged
in, another fellow.

DOUG
Gibble, what are you talking about?

GIBBLE
Gable's gone and winked us both.
It's hard to explain. Rage in me,
etc. You better come with me.

DOUG
(panicking)
Okay ... okay ... okay ...

Doug hands Marlowe the completed form. Gibble and Doug exit.

MARLOWE

Crashaw, our former fellow says his mutt came to be amissing on account of fire.

CRASHAW

Marlowe, you best get out the form for "calamities by fire".

EXT. ORTHODONTIST - DAY

Gibble and Doug arrive at the Orthodontist. A "Grand Opening" banner runs across the second level.

Gable welcomes people into the boat: clientele similar to that of the Orthodontist II. A photographer takes photos of the scene.

Gibble and Doug approach him.

DOUG

Gable what's going on?

GIBBLE

Yes, Gable, tell us what's going on, why don't'chu.

GABLE

Well, Doug, my boy, it seems we've found ourself in a bit of a miscommunication.

The bouncer from the Orthodontist II comes up beside Doug and konks him on the head. Doug blacks out and falls.

INT. ORTHODONTIST / BELOW DECK - NIGHT

A very similar setup to that in the Orthodontist II, except lower-tech. There's the same ring / vestibule / audience setup. A mechanical scoreboard hangs on one of the walls.

Two alligators are in each of the vestibules, one of which is clearly Pebbles. The other alligator is much larger.

Doug, still unconscious, is tied up while standing in the audience, with a clear view of the ring. A sock is in his mouth. The bouncer guards him.

Doug wakes up and tries to scream, but the bouncer kicks him.

A bell goes off, and the fight starts. Doug tears up. The bouncer forces him to watch.

Gable appears at Doug's side.

GABLE

This is what beasts are made for,
Doug ... "Each after their own kind
... these also shall be unclean
unto you among the creeping things
that creep upon the earth" ...

The fighting continues, but quickly Pebbles is killed by the other alligator. Doug weeps.

GABLE

"And he shall slay the dragon that
is in the sea, the crooked
serpent."

(to bouncer)

Get him out of here.

The bouncer drags Doug away.

EXT. ORTHODONTIST - NIGHT

Doug is thrown onto the ground by the bouncer, still tied up.

Gibble and Gable appear after him. Doug looks at Gibble pleadingly.

GABLE

Doug, as you well know, "that which
befalleth the sons of men befalleth
beasts ... as the one dieth, so
dieth the other."

GIBBLE

(sincere)

Okay, Gable, okay, alright now. Let
him go. He ain't up to anything.
You got what you wanted.

(to Doug)

Doug-o, sweets. I didn't mean for
it to work out this way. Family
pressure, etc. You know how it is.

GABLE

Hear that, Doug-o? You've got an
angel upon your cocked head. And
who be I to swerve a seraph.

(to bouncer)

Go ahead, untie 'im.

The bouncer unties Doug, and Doug gets up.

GABLE

Now, Doug, don't take this act of mercy as a carte blanche. You still ain't welcome right round.

DOUG

You're sick ... how could you do this to Pebbles ...

The bouncer kicks him.

GABLE

Don't test my mercy, now. Recall: "there be just men, unto whom it happeneth according to the work of the wicked". It is well-known.

Doug gets back up.

GABLE

Now get on it. I don't want to look at'chu.

Doug gets up and starts limping away. He notices Gibble's truck nearby and moves faster toward it. He picks up a large stone along the way.

He gets inside the truck and turns it on, the keys still in the ignition, and puts it in gear.

Gibble and Gable run toward him.

Doug positions the truck so the boat is in its direct path. Doug plops the stone on the gas pedal and quickly jumps out.

The truck speeds toward the Orthodontist. Gibble and Gable jump out of the way.

The truck crashes into the boat, causing a huge hole. The people in/on the boat attempt to escape. Some alligators escape and chomp on people. Blood colors the water.

Gibble and Gable run back to the boat to help. A fire explodes from the bottom of the boat.

Doug disappears into the marshes.

GABLE

(muttering)

"And the posts of the door moved at the voice of him that cried, and the house was filled with smoke."

EXT. ORTHODONTIST - DAY

The Orthodontist is mostly burned down but no longer on fire. Firetrucks drive away.

Only Gibble and Gable remain, looking at the wreck.

A cab arrives.

GIBBLE
Comin' Gable?

GABLE
No, no. I'll stay with her for now.

Gibble gets in and the cab leaves.

Gable limps to a nearby log and takes off his shirt. He throws the shirt on the log and lies down with his neck on it, feet stretched toward the boat; he falls asleep, snoring.

Doug quietly rustles himself out of the marshes and sneaks past Gable.

He wades into the water and looks for something. He roams around the remains of the boat and eventually finds it: a floating alligator hand, the one with Pebbles' ring on it.

He takes the alligator hand and gets out of the water, trying to sneak back past Gable.

GABLE
(muttering)
Best hurry, just man.

DOUG
You're a beast.

Gable tries to get up, but Doug kicks his ribs.

GABLE
(coughing)
I suppose I am. Well, get on it
then: "they that wait upon the Lord
shall renew their strength", and I
do wait upon the Lord.

Doug leaves; Gable faints.

EXT. DOUG'S HOUSE - DAY

Doug arrives on foot to the remains of his house. He looks around the garage and pulls out a partially charred, full-size spade.

He digs a 3-foot-ish deep hole in the yard and pulls out Pebbles' paw from his clothes.

DOUG
(to the paw)
I should have listened to you. I
didn't understand.

He kisses the paw, places it gently into the hole, and covers it back up as the sun sets.

INT. BUS 1 (EVERGLADES) - NIGHT - TRAVELING

Doug snores, still in the same clothes, on a bus going toward Miami on highway 41 through the Everglades.

INT. TRUCK STOP (MIAMI OUTSKIRTS) - DAY

Doug looks for clothes in a large, multi-shop truck stop. He peers through a rack of "Big Dog" T-shirts.

INSERT - THE T-SHIRTS

The text of each shirt, with matching "Big Dog" image: "I Don't Give a Truck" "Truck-off, Mother-trucker" "Hotrod + Truckold Couple" "Truck My Zrick" "It's Your Trucky Day" "I'm My Own Good Truck Charm"

BACK TO SCENE

Doug takes the shirt that reads "I'm My Own Good Truck Charm". He takes a pair of cargo shorts from a nearby rack.

He proceeds to a shower area with his new clothes.

EXT. TRUCK STOP - DAY

Doug crouches in the parking lot in his new clothes. He tries to "talk" to some pigeons about where to go next.

Moments later a bus with "Orlando" written on top pulls into the truck stop.

Doug approaches the bus, talks to the driver, and boards.

INT. BUS 2 (KISSIMMEE PRAIRIE) - DAY - TRAVELING

The bus to Orlando is driving on 441, just east of Kissimmee prairie. The estate lies visible in the distance.

Doug is half asleep toward the back of the bus, head against a window.

Outside the window, Doug sees a ghost-like Rilke sitting comfortably in the prairie watching sheep roam. Doug sees the estate in the background.

Rilke looks at Doug, then looks away. Rilke runs towards the direction of the estate and finally disappears.

Doug jolts up and works his way to the front of the bus. He begs the bus driver to stop. After some heated back-and-forth, the driver eventually relents and pulls over.

EXT. ESTATE / OUTER GROUNDS - DAY

Doug, in his T-shirt and shorts, walks along the road adjacent to the estate's plot. He comes up to a gate that opens to a long driveway to the estate.

Just beyond the gate Margot rides a horse while holding the huge remote for her orange-shooting delivery robot.

END FLASHBACK**BLACK SCREEN**

SUPER: "Six Months After the Death of the Baroness"

EXT. CYPRESS GROVE - NIGHT

Margot, Worm, and Snake rush in their fan boat back toward Gobble's cabin.

Margot continually fiddles with her phone.

INSERT - MARGOT'S PHONE

Margot refreshes a "Call Helicopter" app, which shows a "No Signal" error.

BACK TO SCENE

EXT. GIBBLE'S GAMBOL / MUD BATH - NIGHT

Doug still lies asleep in the mud. Gible is dressed nearby.

Gable walks up behind Doug and points a shotgun at the top of his head. Gible goes to stand across from them.

GABLE

"Again ... there be wicked men ...
to whom it happeneth according to
the work of the righteous".

Doug opens his eyes, panicked. Rilke barks once, and Doug shushes him.

DOUG

Wait, what? Gible ... this is what
you meant by "heart attack"?

GIBBLE

I'm sorry, sweets. You know how he
gets.

GABLE

Up you, out of that horrible pit.

Doug gets out, covered in mud, but wearing a bathing suit.
Gable keeps the gun pointed at him.

GABLE

Now, we have a bit of reckoning to
reckon.

DOUG

Just ... leave Rilke out of it.

GABLE

What on this forsaken earth is a
Rilke?

GIBBLE

That dog right there, Gabes.

GABLE

Ah, yes. Now that dog ... that dog
got stamina.

DOUG

Leave him out of it!

GABLE

Well that'll be entirely up to the
reckoning. You see ... I've seen
your accompanying party's pockets.

GIBBLE
Pockets ran deep.

DOUG
Yes, of course, we'll pay you.
Whatever you want.

GABLE
A real upright citizens brigade we
got on our hands, Gibbs.

GIBBLE
Seems so, Gabes.

Margot, Worm, Snake arrive at the cabin in their boat, still
some distance from the mud bath. Worm carries the bag with
the caiman.

They call for Rilke; Rilke barks. They wind their way over to
the mud pool.

MARGOT
I knew this lean-fleshed cow stunk.

GABLE
If it isn't my sweet 'Rach, 'Shach,
and Abed'. But will they bow?

MARGOT
What do you want?

GABLE
See, I'm fixing to paw around in
them pockets a bit more. Turns out
Doug here owes me quite a hefty
weight.

MARGOT
We aren't his guarantors, nor he
our ward, pigskin.

GABLE
No, I suppose not. But the dog is,
I suppose so.

MARGOT
I don't give a fuck about the dog.
Dog makes my life worse by the
minute.

DOUG
Margot!

GABLE

Truly is a shame ... "He that troubleth his own house shall inherit the wind", and, turns out, I got plenty of winds for the five of y'all.

The helicopter suddenly arrives close by. It sprays up some grass and dust over everyone. A handful of rocks gets kicked up and hits Gable in the back, causing him to drop the gun and fall over.

MARGOT

Run!

Everyone except Gable runs toward the helicopter. Rilke makes it to the helicopter and jumps in.

Gable, still at the mud bath, gropes around for the gun with difficulty and finally picks it back up. He shoots at the runners but ends up hitting Gibble. Gibble tumbles.

Margot gets in the helicopter. Gable starts running toward the helicopter. The rest all make it to the helicopter, including the caiman. The helicopter takes off.

Gable shoots a couple rounds at the helicopter but misses. As the helicopter disappears, Gable gets to Gibble's body and sinks down over him, attempting to staunch Gibble's wound.

EXT. ESTATE / PATIO - NIGHT

The helicopter sets down at the same spot it took off from. Everyone jumps out looking bedraggled.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Margot stands, at the door, eating Vegemite from a jar, still in her Everglades clothes. Morgan looks at her from his desk.

MORGAN

Did you have a bucolic bumbling with our sweet boy, Margotron?

MARGOT

"Nobody" almost bit our heads off, unfortunately.

MORGAN

You do smell a bit ovine.

MARGOT

Would that Athena show me tall and bright. Regardless, I've brought the sheep for slaughter, Morganic.

MORGAN

Is that so?

Margot reveals the envelope from Gable's nephew, pulls out the newspaper clipping, and hands it to Morgan.

Morgan reads it over.

INSERT - THE CLIPPING

A picture of Doug with Pebbles. Lede: "Gladesman Guts Green Gator Getaway Dinghy, Gets Away".

BACK TO SCENE

MORGAN

Fuck me. I shoop me into shroudes.

MARGOT

As he a sheep were.

Margot leaves. Morgan gets on the phone.

MORGAN

Hello, Ms. Truss. Yes, this is Morgan Ehrlich. Sorry for the hour. Some trouble in paradise, I'm afraid ...

INT. PAWS 4 PEOPLE - NIGHT

Kids and parents are playing with cats and dogs. Margot plays with Rilke and some other kids. Doug and Jerry play with a cat on the floor.

Morgan talks to Charita elsewhere. Charita looks excited.

DOUG

Are you happy with the cats we got you, little Jerry?

JERRY

Absolutely, big Doug. They are so random.

DOUG

I couldn't agree more. Cats ARE random.

Morgan makes some motions toward Margot and Charita that signify "closing time".

Charita rounds up the kids, and Margot takes Rilke out. Morgan goes to fetch Doug.

MORGAN

Doug, it's about closing up time.
Little Jerry, we'll see you soon.

Jerry leaves, carrying the cat to Charita.

DOUG

Hard to see them deprived.

MORGAN

Yes, I suppose so.

INT. MORGAN'S LIMO - NIGHT - TRAVELING

Morgan and Margot flank Rilke on one side of the limo, while Doug and Charita sit across from them.

MORGAN

Doug, you've really embarrassed us.
Rilke especially.

DOUG

What are you talking about?

Morgan hands Doug an official court order.

MORGAN

You hereby have been stripped from
our late matron's last will and
testament. We thought, and the
judge agreed, that your unstable,
likely criminal, history makes you
unfit for service as Rilke's
warden, and, had our dear Baroness
known about said seedy past, she,
too, would have so thought in
likeness to us.

DOUG

You can't do this.

MORGAN

With express assent, we have so
done it.

DOUG

But, Rilke ... he needs me ...

MORGAN

In fact, Doug, he needs you not,
and he needs you to not. Now, of
course, this is ten odd years ago,
so your case has passed even the
Florida statute of limitations ...

DOUG

(interrupting)

You don't understand. You don't
know what happened. I don't know
what Gable told you. He's a liar.
He's tricking you.

MORGAN

It's all a matter of public record,
in fact.

Morgan hands him a copy of the newspaper clipping.

DOUG

This isn't what happened ... don't
you get it? They killed my
alligator! My Pebbles!

MORGAN

And, thank you, speaking of our
wrinkled, vellum-like mutual
friend, Gable, your potential
slaughter of a man named Gibble,
unfortunately for you, unlike your
arson, has not passed the statute
of limitations.

DOUG

What?! You talked to him? That's
what he told you. Margot, you know
that's not what happened!

MARGOT

All I know is that I got in the
helicopter, and, when I turn
around, you're running straight
from a dead-and-grounded Gibble.

DOUG

(to both)

Why are you doing this?

MORGAN AND MARGOT

(together)

You're unfit to care for our dear
Rilke.

MORGAN

Of course, this means you'll no longer be allowed to stay on the property. We've graciously decided to give you 24 hours to figure out your next steps.

Margot puts headphones in and dials a number on her phone.

DOUG

So, it'll just be you two taking care of him?

MORGAN

No, no. Charita, here, has been appointed interim warden for our sweet boy.

CHARITA

I will take such good care of him!

Doug cries, and Morgan smirks.

MARGOT

(into headphones)

Hey, can I put 500 on Laurel and 500 on Hardy ... What do you mean that's one horse ... You're telling me that there's one horse called Laurel-and-Hardy ... That's fucking cuckoo, dude ... Whatever, okay ... 500 on Laurel-and-Hardy, and 500 on ... Abbott-and-Costello ... okay, that one's two horses ... eesh ... what about Bonzo-Dog? ... that's just an actual dog called Bonzo, sure ... okay, okay, just the 500 on Laurel-and-Hardy ...

MORGAN

Margot! What the fuck ...

Margot grimaces at Morgan and hangs up.

MARGOT

What ... it's a bigass race.

INT. ESTATE / DOUG'S ROOM - NIGHT

Doug paces around the room while Gunther lies on the bed.

DOUG

They don't give an iota of care
about Rilke.

GUNTHER

True, meine Maus. They are ... wie
sagt man ... Assbirths.

DOUG

Yes, Gunther, they are absolute
Assbirths.

RILKE'S VOICE (V.O.)

The world will be my widow and
still weep / That I no form of me
have left behind ...

Doug looks around and sighs.

DOUG

Look, Gunther, we are going to have
to rectify the behavior of these
assbirths. We have to help Rilke. I
need your help: we both do.

GUNTHER

What do you mean, kleine Doug?

DOUG

Rilke's line has to be continued.
We have to take Rilke to a bitch
I've lined up, to procreate, to
make more Rilke. We'll use your
motorcycle. We'll go early in the
morning tomorrow.

GUNTHER

Mäuschen ... certainly there's
another way.

DOUG

There really isn't, my love.

GUNTHER

I was hoping to peacefully stay
here, meine Maus. I like it here
... I'd really like to stay ...

DOUG

I know, Gunther-guss. But some
things are bigger than us, which
require sacrifice. "Let us be
sacrificers, but not butchers".
Rilke continuing is bigger than us.

Gunther tears up.

GUNTHER
Okay, meine Maus. Morgen we shall
go. Early morning.

DOUG
Thank you, my sweet tennis-boy. Do
you still have that pistol?

Gunther looks at him concerned and nods.

INT. ESTATE / RILKE'S ROOM - DAY

Rilke's room is empty. The bureau displays a recently picked
treat. A motorcycle starts up outside.

EXT. ESTATE / GARAGE - DAY

Just outside the garage, Gunther revs an old BMW boxer
motorcycle that has a sidecar attachment.

Doug clutches Gunther on the pillion. Both wear backpacks.
Rilke sits in the sidecar wearing goggles and a helmet.

Gunther presses a button to open the gate and they drive off.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - DAY

Margot walks into the kitchen and finds a note from Doug.

INSERT - THE NOTE

"We'll bring Rilke back soon. His line must continue."

BACK TO SCENE

MARGOT
Morgan!

Margot runs toward Morgan's office.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - DAY

Morgan sits at his desk when Margot rushes in.

MARGOT
Yo, our wizard took our dog.

Margot hands him the note.

MORGAN
Fucking wizard.

MARGOT
I think he's bringing him to fuck
some bitch.

MORGAN
Ah, you're right. I remember mother
mentioning something about some
bitch-haver moving into the area
not too long ago.

Morgan rifles through a bunch of files and pulls out an
address book that belonged to the baroness. He flips through
it and finds an entry labeled "Bitches/Breeders".

MORGAN
Alright, let's go.

They rush out.

EXT. CITRUS FARM / HOUSE - DAY

Doug and Gunther talk to TERRA, a no-nonsense citrus farmer,
outside of her large farmhouse.

A long, dirt driveway leads to the house, Gunther's
motorcycle on it. Acres of citrus trees grow in rows nearby.

Rilke is sniffing a female German Shepherd named Praline.

GUNTHER
You have a beautiful home, Terra.

TERRA
Thank you.

DOUG
Can we get a copy of the breeding
documents for Praline?

TERRA
Absolutely. If a litter occurs,
I'll include a copy with your share
of the litter.

DOUG
Thank you so much. Really. You have
no idea.

Rilke and Praline run off into the trees.

TERRA

You want a tour of the Grove?

GUNTHER

Sure!

Just then in the distance, gravel gets kicked up by cars speeding up the driveway. The cars get closer and closer: Morgan's limo and a police car.

DOUG

Actually, Gunther, why don't you go start the bike.

Gunther goes to the motorcycle and starts tinkering.

The other cars eventually arrive in front of the house.

Morgan and Margot get out of the limo. Crashaw and Marlowe get out of the police car.

MARGOT

Not cool, Doug-o-tron.

DOUG

Like you care. You never cared about him.

(to Terra)

Terra, these are the legal owners. I'm sorry to involve you in this.

Gunther struggles to start the bike.

TERRA

What is happening?

MORGAN

Time for Rilke to come home, Doug.

Crashaw and Marlowe zone out. Doug quickly recites a sonnet, to stall for time, while the others look on him in disgust.

DOUG

(eyeing Gunther)

Is it for fear to wet a widow's eye
/ That thou consum'st thyself in
single life?

(MORE)

DOUG (CONT'D)
 / Ah, if thou issueless shalt hap
 to die, / The world will wail thee
 like a makeless wife; / The world
 will be thy widow and still weep /
 That thou no form of thee hast left
 behind, / When every private widow
 well may keep, / By children's
 eyes, her husband's shape in mind.
 / Look what an unthrift in the
 world doth spend / Shifts but his
 place, for still the world enjoys
 it; / But beauty's waste hath in
 the world an end, / And, kept
 unused, the user so destroys it ...

Gunther turns the motorcycle on, and Doug runs toward him.

DOUG (CONT'D)
 ... No love toward others in that
 bosom sits / That on himself such
 murd'rous shame commits.

Doug hops in the sidecar, and they drive away. Morgan yells
 at Marlowe and Crashaw to chase them.

MARGOT
 (to Terra)
 That guy's fucking nuts!

MORGAN
 We have a court order against him.

TERRA
 I'm so sorry. I'll fetch the dogs.

Terra runs into the trees. Margot follows, plucking oranges.

MARGOT
 (yelling)
 You got any baskets for these orbs?

EXT. CITRUS FARM / ORCHARD - DAY

In their respective vehicles, Marlowe and Crashaw chase
 Gunther and Doug. They snake through the citrus rows. Gunther
 struggles to keep the bike upright.

They pass Rilke humping Praline. Soon, the police car hits a
 tree and goes up in smoke.

Gunther quickly finds a dirt road and takes it to a highway,
 driving off into the distance.

Later, Terra finds Rilke and Praline sleeping under a tree.

EXT. MOTEL MARIACHI (ORLANDO) - DAY

Gunther and Doug arrive at a Spanish-style motel that's old but not gross. The motel has a pool. Nearby is a cafe called "Dizzy Knee Coffee".

Gunther parks the bike, and Doug goes into the lobby.

INT. MOTEL MARIACHI / LOBBY - DAY

Two assistant managers, MILTON, a middle-aged slow-talking male, and COWLEY, a middle-aged, slow-talking female, loaf about bored behind a typical counter. Doug huffs in.

DOUG

Hi, I need to get a room. I'm not sure how long.

MILTON

Hear that, Cowley. The fellow's non-committal.

COWLEY

Another noncommittal fellow, Milton? Say, Milton: how could it that a man might "be" non-committal? Should he be it, he'd be it, and should he be it not, he'd also be it not.

DOUG

Please, sir, ma'am. "I do count the clock that tells the time" ...

MILTON

(interrupting)

I don't well reckon your point, Cowley. I suspect that, for a man to be non-committal, it does not follow that he is so committed therein to his non-committal-hood.

COWLEY

Non-committal-hood, absolutely.

DOUG

(annoyed)

So ... do you have any rooms?

COWLEY

Milton, get him that form for non-committal persons.

Milton locates a form and hands it to Doug.

INSERT - FORM 1

The top of the form reads "Guest(s), Risky". The rest of the form contains fields for information.

BACK TO SCENE

DOUG

Please, my partner and I aren't dangerous. We can pay in cash.

MILTON

I'm sorry, fellow. That's the only form we have for non-committal persons.

COWLEY

We only got two forms for persons, I fear, and that one there is the one for those non-committal, that one he gave you, in your very hand.

Milton locates a different form and hands it to Doug.

INSERT - FORM 2

The top of the form reads "Guest(s), Trusted". The rest of the form contains fields for information, including boxes for "Dates Staying".

BACK TO SCENE

MILTON

See on this form, you must fill out your "Dates Staying" in the box.

Doug looks over the two forms.

DOUG

Fine, fine. We just need to sleep.

Milton takes the second form from Doug and looks it over. Doug starts filling out the first form.

MILTON

You know, Cowley, we might could consider adding "Dates Pending" boxes.

COWLEY

Well, Milton. That would be quite the augmentation.

MILTON

An awe-ing augmentation, should it ever so occur. Had we done so, fellow, even just this morning, it would have been your lucky day.

COWLEY

Each day be lucky, or none, Milton. Now, Milton, would it be that the present form unaugmented could as the former form unaugmented called the same be?

MILTON

I reckon, without it being the same of properties, the present form augmented would only, in a certain way, pertain to the former.

COWLEY

Pertains, pertains, absolutely.

Gunther enters the lobby.

GUNTHER

(to Doug)

Meine Maus, I'm exhausted. Utterly, utterly stinkfished.

MILTON

Cowley, look what the mutt dragged in, another fellow.

DOUG

Okay ... okay ... okay ...

Doug hands Milton the complete form and some cash.

Gunther and Doug head toward the exit.

MILTON

Cowley, our former fellow says he does indeed have flammables amongst his effects.

COWLEY

Milton, you best get out the form for "potential calamities by fire".

INT. MOTEL MARIACHI / KING-BED ROOM - NIGHT

Doug and Gunther collapse on a creaky king-sized bed.

EXT. ESTATE / GARAGE - NIGHT

Morgan and Margot lead Rilke toward the house.

INT. ESTATE / SALON - NIGHT

Rilke sleeps on the chaise longue, his head toward the backrest side.

INT. MOTEL MARIACHI / KING-BED ROOM - DAY

Doug and Gunther wake up in the king bed.

DOUG

Do you think Rilke is going to be okay, Gunther-guss?

GUNTHER

I'm not sure, Mäuschen.

DOUG

We'll have to make sure.

Gunther grunts and gets out of bed. He undresses down to his underwear and leaves the room.

Doug gets up and rifles through a backpack. He pulls out Gunther's gun and "Sonnets of Shakespeare".

He goes to a table and reads. He soon finds in the book the business card that Worm and Snake had given him. He looks the card over, twirls it in his fingers, thinking.

He then undresses and does yoga on the floor. Pebbles appears on the bed.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - DAY

Morgan is on the phone with Stinger.

MORGAN

Stinger, get everybody ready for the merger ... Yes, Saudi-Cloudi, included ... We're in the home stretch ...

He hangs up and dials another number.

MORGAN

Hi, detective ... I'm getting a little impatient on the continued absence of our dognapper ... yes, please keep me apprised ...

EXT. MOTEL MARIACHI / POOL - DAY

Doug and Gunther sun-bathe by the pool in their underwear. Doug starts convulsing. Pebbles briefly appears in the pool.

DOUG

Speak ... and I will listen ...

BEGIN DOUG'S VISION

EXT. RILKE'S SPOT - DAY

Morgan rests on his knees before a large hole. He pushes dirt into the hole. Inside the hole lie Rilke and his pups.

Colin Mochrie arrives and fights Morgan. They tumble into the hole. Morgan knocks Colin Mochrie onto his back.

MORGAN AND MOCHRIE

(together)

Now my charms are all o'erthrown, /
And what strength I have's mine
own, / Which is most faint. Now
'tis true, / I must be here
confin'd by you ...

Morgan gets out of the hole and starts filling it in again.

END DOUG'S VISION

EXT. MOTEL MARIACHI / LOBBY - DAY

Milton and Cowley sit at the desk. Marlowe and Crashaw enter in police uniforms. They all look at each other skeptically.

Doug convulses behind them by the pool.

MARLOWE

Hi, I have a man amissing.

MILTON

Hear that, Cowley. The fellow's got
a man amissing.

COWLEY

Another man amissing, Milton?

COWLEY AND CRASHAW

(together)

How many times must it occur that a
man or mutt be amissing, that you
mention that such-and-such entity
has that man or mutt in such a
state, and finally that I correct
you as to the non-possibility of
such-and-such an entity to so have
a man or mutt in such a state?

Cowley and Crashaw look at each other, perplexed.

MILTON AND MARLOWE

(together)

I hear your point. So, I correct
myself: There seems to be a man
amissing, one that pertains, I
suppose, by right, to these fellows
here.

Milton and Marlowe look at each other, perplexed.

COWLEY AND CRASHAW

(together)

Pertains, pertains, absolutely.

All four look at each other. They all scratch their heads at
the same time. The door flaps open and closes again.

CRASHAW

The man amissing is a known
criminal. A dognapper and potential
killer.

COWLEY

Ah, a purveyor of mutts.

CRASHAW

Non-exotic-like. And a history with
exotic-like, too.

Gunther notices Marlowe and Crashaw from the pool, and he
drags Doug to their room.

Marlowe produces a stack of posters with Doug's picture on
them. Milton hands one to Marlowe.

MARLOWE

This is what he looks like. Seen him? Street cameras caught an old BMW motorcycle cruising around these parts.

MILTON

Can't say I have, officers.

Milton hands one to Cowley.

COWLEY

Nor I, officers.

MARLOWE AND CRASHAW

(together)

You let us know if you see anything of any such-and-such a sort.

CRASHAW

And kindly make advertisement of some such of these photos up around your establishment.

MILTON AND COWLEY

(together)

Our pleasure, officers.

Crashaw and Marlowe leave, completely missing Gunther's motorcycle in the parking lot.

BEGIN DOUG'S VISION

EXT. RILKE'S SPOT - DAY

Morgan finishes filling in the hole from before.

MORGAN

And my ending is despair, / Unless
I be reliev'd by prayer, / Which
pierces so that it assaults / Mercy
itself, and frees all faults. / As
you from crimes would pardon'd be,
/ Let your indulgence set me free.

END DOUG'S VISION

INT. MOTEL MARIACHI / KING-BED ROOM - DAY

Gunther sets Doug on the bed. Doug snaps out of it.

DOUG
It's not over, Gunther-guss. We
have more work to do.

GUNTHER
(interrupting)
Shh. Get some sleep, meine Maus.

Doug falls asleep. Gunther looks over the table where Doug
had pulled out the gun.

INT. MOTEL MARIACHI / LOBBY - DAY

Doug withdraws some cash from the motel's ATM. Doug leaves
and walks toward Dizzy Knee Coffee.

Gunther swims in the pool in his underwear. He doesn't notice
Doug leaving.

INT. GOON'S LAB - DAY

Worm runs within a human-sized hamster wheel, while Snake is
at a computer monitoring Worm's heart rate and other vitals.

The caiman that Worm caught is in a well-kept, large cage.

A phone rings. Snake stops what he is doing and looks
haphazardly for the phone.

Worm slips and spins around the wheel on his belly.

SNAKE finds the phone and answers.

SNAKE
You've reached Nice Goons, Inc. How
can we help you do stuff, legally?
... Is that right? ... Yeah we can
do that. That's our specialty,
actually: exotic and non-exotic
mutts ... you know Dizzy Knee
Coffee, I have a "buy-10-get-1-
free" card from there ... you do,
perfect, we'll see you tomorrow.

SNAKE hangs up. Worm's wheel comes to a halt.

SNAKE
We got a job, dingus.

They look at each other and fist-pump repeatedly.

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
Nice goons!

EXT. DIZZY KNEE CAFE (ORLANDO) - DAY

Worm and Snake sit on the same side of a table in a large patio area that's mostly empty. A couple off-brand Disney-like characters/costumes walk around.

Doug sits somewhere in a distant part of the patio.

WORM
You ever hear of "thumping"? It's a practice ...

SNAKE
(interrupting)
Yes.

WORM
I think I might want to get really into thumping.

SNAKE
No, you don't.

WORM
You don't know what it is.

SNAKE
I know it; I've done it.

WORM
You've never thumped.

SNAKE
Yes, I have; it sucks ass.

WORM
Okay. What is it then?

SNAKE
It's when you are having a threeway with at least one M, and two members of the threeway are kissing such that an M is left not kissing, and those two kissers, each M or F, repeatedly fist-konk the hard dick of the third, non-kissing M.

WORM
 (under breath)
 Fist ... bonk ...

SNAKE
 Fist-konk.

WORM
 Fist-cock.

SNAKE
 Fist-konk third cock.

WORM
 Fist fist fist, konk konk konk ...
 What the fuck are you talking
 about?

SNAKE
 The practice of thumping.

WORM
 This is not at all what I'm talking
 about, you fucking freak. You did
 that shit? BDSM-a-trois shit?

SNAKE
 Yes, once. It sucks ass. Once-and-
 a-half, actually.

Jerry, the child from the charity, walks up to the table,
 rubbing an obvious/operative earpiece.

Worm and Snake look skeptical.

JERRY
 Look at these two nice goons.

WORM AND SNAKE
 (together)
 Who are you, little boy?

JERRY
 I'm the person who hired two nice
 goons.

WORM AND SNAKE
 (together)
 You are a little boy.

JERRY
 Just look at my little-boy ear.

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
That's awesome.

SNAKE
Orders delivered by a little boy.

WORM
Real pleasure to meet you, boss, in
the flesh of a little boy.

Jerry hands them a small note card with typed orders on it,
and a wad of cash.

JERRY
Here's the job requirements and
half the payment. Fill in the
details as you see fit. The other
half once it's done.

Jerry gets up to leave

WORM AND SNAKE
(together)
Hold up.

Jerry pauses, touches his ear.

SNAKE
We want a picture with the little
boy, for our files.

WORM
Our first official jobbo, and even
with a little boy.

Snake rummages around in a bag and pulls out a polaroid.

INT. SPORTING GOODS STORE (ORLANDO) - DAY

Worm and Snake shop for dog-catching supplies. Worm carries a
large net. He "catches" Snake in the net.

WORM
Nothing but net!

SNAKE
We gotta take this job real
serious, goonhead. Our first job
could make or break us.

WORM

I'm taking it serious, losertron. I already bought a dog manual online.

SNAKE

What the fuck is a "dog manual"?

WORM

That's what I got the manual for.

SNAKE

Jesus Christ.

INT. GOON'S LAB - NIGHT

Snake sifts through a bunch of dog-napping materials: nets, jumpsuits, dog-treats, etc.

Worm stands reading a book called "Cynegeticus" by Xenophon.

WORM

This dude Xenophon's got some sick ideas about hunting.

SNAKE

Come help me, lethargy-lunk.

WORM

"The net-keeper should wear a light costume", he says. Okay, we should wear those jumpsuits: they're moisture wicking.

SNAKE

Wicking sucks.

WORM

Whatever ... "In hunting, 'no procrastination' should be the motto, since it is sportsmanlike at once and a proof of energy by all means to effect a capture quickly."

SNAKE

Stop reading that loser shit and help me out.

WORM

Chill out. I've already got the tranquilizers plump.

SNAKE

We still have to reinforce the
catchpole.

Snake trips and loses his breath. He struggles to get back up
amongst the stuff.

WORM

"For breeding purposes choose
winter, and release the bitches
from hard work" ... boring ...
boring ...

He flips through some pages.

WORM (CONT'D)

Boring ... okay: "They should have
short names given them, which will
be easy to call out: Psyche, Pluck,
Buckler, Spigot, Lance, Lurcher,
Watch, Keeper, Brigade, Fencer,
Butcher, Blazer, Prowess,
Craftsman, Forester, Counsellor ...

Snake throws something at him from the ground.

WORM (CONT'D)

... Spoiler, Hurry, Fury, Growler,
Riot, Bloomer, Rome, Blossom, Hebe,
Hilary, Jolity, Gazer, Eyebright,
Much, Force, Trooper, Bustle,
Bubbler, Rockdove, Stubborn, Yelp,
Killer, Pele-mele, Strongboy, Sky,
Sunbeam, Bodkin, Wistful, Gnome,
Tracks, Dash ... "

Snake wheezes up. He snatches the book and throws it out a
window.

WORM

That was my favorite book.

EXT. MOTEL MARIACHI - NIGHT

Gunther and Doug drive off on the motorcycle.

EXT. ESTATE / OUTER GROUNDS - NIGHT

Gunther and Doug stop along a road that is adjacent to the
estate grounds. The estate is walled off by large bushes.

Doug leads them through a small passage in the bushes.

EXT. ESTATE / GARDEN - NIGHT

Doug and Gunther exit the wall of bushes into the garden.

DOUG

Okay, Gunther-guss. You go get
whatever you need. Meet back here
in half an hour.

GUNTHER

Absolutely, meine Liebe.

Gunther kisses Doug on the forehead.

Doug heads toward the house, and Gunther heads toward the tennis court.

EXT./INT. WHITE VAN (ESTATE GROUNDS) - NIGHT - TRAVELING

Snake drives a white van while Worm prepares tranquilizer guns in the back. A variety of supplies and tools are in the back, including a handgun and a full-sized spade.

Snake is wearing a jumpsuit from earlier. Worm is wearing one of the grass camouflage outfits from the Everglades trip.

They drive past Gunther's motorcycle on the side of the road.

WORM

This shit is gnarly strong, just
FYI.

SNAKE

What?

WORM

(yelling)
Just FYI!

SNAKE

(yelling)
What is?!

WORM

The tranqs!

SNAKE

What is the information about them?

WORM

They are gnarly as shit.

SNAKE

No shit.

WORM
No, as shit.

SNAKE
Are they ready or not?

WORM
Ready and gnarly.

SNAKE
Just shut the fuck up.

Worm drops a box of tranquilizer ammo onto the floor. They don't break, but they scatter.

Snake and Worm lock eyes in the rear-view mirror.

WORM
We got time!

They arrive at the estate's driveway. They open the gate and pass through.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Margot peels an orange while wearing headphones. Doug walks in, gets startled, and jumps back, quietly.

Margot, between him and the hallways leading eventually to Rilke's room, doesn't notice and starts to eat her orange.

Margot finds the orange distasteful. She turns around to rummage in the fridge, causing several oranges to fall onto the ground and roll toward Doug.

Doug takes this opportunity to try to scoot past her while she rummages. Doug doesn't see the oranges and slips on one, landing on his back and getting the wind knocked out of him.

Margot, startled, slams the fridge door closed.

MARGOT
Zoinks! Well look who the fancy dog
drug in. Home again, home again,
diggity-Doug.

DOUG
(wheezing)
Margot, please. You know all I've
ever wanted was to help our king.

MARGOT

I actually don't know that, Doug-o-tron. I could not know it, even if I wanted to.

DOUG

I never wanted to hurt anybody. I just wanted Rilke to live ... forever ...

MARGOT

Spare me, wizard.

Margot crouches down near his face.

MARGOT

I'm going to trim your nails, wizard.

Doug finds an orange on the floor with his hand and bashes it into Margot's head.

She jumps up and stumbles backward, holding her eye. She slips on another orange and falls backward such that her head hits the fridge. She slides into a sitting position with her head slumped forward.

Doug gets up and fixes her posture.

DOUG

I'm sorry, Margot.

MARGOT

(whispering)
Vitamin ... can't see ...

Margot blacks out. Doug proceeds to the hallway toward Rilke's room.

EXT. ESTATE / TENNIS COURT - NIGHT

Gunther is alone on one side of the court with a racket and balls. His backpack is on the ground nearby.

GUNTHER

Okay, Rilke. Deep left.

Gunther lobs a ball toward the deep left of the opposing side of the court.

GUNTHER

Good boy, Rilke. Okay, mid center.

Gunther lobbs a ball toward the mid center of the opposing side of the court.

GUNTHER
A bit sluggish, Rilke, but nice
save.

Gunther checks for more balls, but he has run out.

GUNTHER
Okay, Rilke. That's enough for now.
For now ...

Gunther goes to his backpack and pulls out his gun. He looks around at the estate.

GUNTHER
It really is quite peaceful here.
And I will remain here, quite
peaceful.

He puts the gun to the side of his head, pulls the trigger, and slumps onto the ground with a bang.

INT. ESTATE / RILKE'S ROOM - NIGHT

Doug slowly, quietly enters Rilke's room while Rilke is sleeping.

A gunshot goes off in the distance. Doug jumps, and Rilke wakes up.

DOUG
Rilke, my sweet one. It's time to
get you out of here. Your owners
... they're not safe.

Rilke barks quietly.

DOUG
I know, I know. We'll be okay.
Let's get you a treat.

Doug picks out a treat from Rilke's electronic bureau and gives it to Rilke. Rilke barks again.

DOUG
Shhh, my love. Okay, let's go.

Doug leashes Rilke and leads him out the door. Rilke follows willingly.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Worm and Snake slink into the kitchen with tranquilizer guns slung around their backs.

Worm's caiman is on a leash attached to Worm's suit. The caiman has been gnawing at the leash, and it has a smoke bomb attached to its back.

Snake tries to wake Margot up, to no avail. Worm eats an orange like an apple.

Doug walks in and the goons immediately notice.

WORM

What the fuck, Doug-dingus. You're not supposed to be here.

DOUG

Just, you know, taking Rilke for his nightly walk.

SNAKE

The fuck you are.

Snake pulls up his gun and shoots at Doug, but he misses. Doug and Rilke run for it.

The caiman snaps its leash and starts running around, bumping the smoke bomb's trigger. Smoke fills the kitchen.

SNAKE

Goddamn it, Worm. Xenophon my ass.

Worm and Snake run after Doug and Rilke, violently coughing.

INT. ESTATE / BALLET ROOM - NIGHT

The caiman runs around confused as smoke thinly trails. It pauses briefly upon seeing itself in the mirror.

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Morgan sits at his desk. On his desk sits the box with old family photos. One of the goons' business cards is at the top of a stack of papers.

Morgan watches a video on an old camera.

ON THE CAMERA

Morgan's father teaches tennis to a child-aged Morgan. A German Shepherd, not Rilke, runs onto the court, cutting off Morgan's father.

Morgan's father chases the dog but slips on a tennis ball near the net. Morgan's father hits his head on the net's pole and quickly dies.

Morgan cries. The camera falls onto the baroness' lap, ending the video.

BACK TO SCENE

Worm's caiman sneaks into Morgan's office. Morgan jumps up.

MORGAN

No!

Morgan empties a trashcan, runs up to the caiman, and traps it in the trashcan. He slumps back into his office chair.

MORGAN

Fucking goons.

EXT. ESTATE / PATIO - NIGHT

The goons chase Doug and Rilke, forcing the latter to go toward the tennis courts, rather than the garden.

EXT. ESTATE / TENNIS COURT - NIGHT

Doug and Rilke run past Gunther's body. Doug looks at it, horrified. The goons are not far behind.

The goons manage to trap Doug and Rilke on the Gunther side of the court, while they take up the opposing side.

The goons shoot at Doug and Rilke with their tranquilizer guns, missing most, but eventually hitting both. Doug and Rilke fall down asleep near Gunther.

Worm and Snake high five and walk up to the three bodies.

WORM

What should we do with this loaf?

SNAKE

Take him with, I guess. Doubt anyone will miss him.

WORM

Respect.

SNAKE

Okay. You take the loaf and the dog. I'll take the wizard.

WORM

Worm's always doing double ...

Worm swings Rilke around his neck and drags Gunther out of the court. Snake picks Doug up and follows Worm.

EXT. ESTATE / DRIVEWAY - NIGHT

The white van sits near the house. Worm and Snake dump the three bodies into the van, and then they jump in front.

EXT./INT. WHITE VAN (ESTATE GROUNDS) - NIGHT - TRAVELING

They drive away from the estate's driveway.

They drive past Gunther's motorcycle in the opposite direction as before.

A little later, a cop car with its sirens on passes the white van, going in the opposite direction as the van, i.e. toward the motorcycle/estate.

INT. POLICE CAR (ESTATE GROUNDS) - NIGHT - TRAVELING

Crashaw drives the car with Marlowe as a passenger. They pass the motorcycle on the side of the road.

MARLOWE

Consider four cases. A man or mutt is amissing in such a way that pertains to him-or-itself or to some other such-and-such an entity. Or, a man or mutt is not amissing to the same, respectively. Surely a man or mutt cannot be amissing in a way that pertains to him-or-itself.

CRASHAW

Granted.

MARLOWE

Now can a man or mutt be amissing in way that pertains to ... well, shoot, I've lost it.

CRASHAW
Your augmentation is a wreck,
Marlowe. An absolutely awful
augmentation.

INT. WHITE VAN (KISSIMMEE PRAIRIE) - NIGHT - TRAVELING

Snake drives, aggressively speeding, and Worm sits in the passenger seat.

In the back, Gunther is in a pool of blood next to Doug and Rilke, who are still konked out.

WORM
I miss Xenophon.

SNAKE
On about that fucking book again?

WORM
No, my caiman.

SNAKE
Strapped a fucking weapon on it.
What do you expect?

WORM
We were buds.

SNAKE
Buds don't strap weapons onto buds.
Remember that.

WORM
Whatever. You don't get it.

SNAKE
What are we going to do about our
bleeding loaf?

WORM
I wonder what Xenophon would say
about the disposal of bodies.

SNAKE
Caiman?

WORM
No, book. Probably need to cut him
up. Make him into some kind of a
prairie situation.

Doug drowsily wakes up. He looks around himself in horror: Rilke appears already dead.

DOUG
(whispering)
Failed again. Failed again. Failed again.

He fumbles around the back of the van, progressively waking up. Worm and Snake are oblivious.

He finds a small gun lying in the back. He gets on his knees and points the gun toward Worm.

DOUG
No more ... Mr. Nice Goon!

Worm turns around and yells.

The van goes over a bump as Doug pulls the trigger, causing him to miss. The bullet ricochets and hits Rilke's leg.

Snake, startled, loses control of the van, and they careen into the side of the road. All parties are knocked out.

INT. ESTATE / RILKE'S ROOM - NIGHT

Morgan enters holding the caiman-bearing trashcan. He seems relieved to find the room empty.

INT. ESTATE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Morgan, holding the trashcan, finds Margot pressing a bag of peas to the back of her head. One of her eyes is bloodshot.

MORGAN
The fuck happened to you.

MARGOT
Did you not hear the fucking ruckus? Prodigal wizard returned, walloped me with an orange.

Morgan takes a moment to think.

MORGAN
Think he got Rilke, too, actually.

MARGOT
God I'm sick of this.

The doorbell rings.

EXT. ESTATE / FRONT DOOR - NIGHT

Crashaw and Marlowe stand at the front door. Morgan and Margot open the door. Morgan no longer has the trashcan.

MORGAN
Evening, officers.

MARLOWE
Evening, fellows. We got a call ...
says that there may be a man and/or
a mutt amissing, both of which
might would pertain to both of you.

MORGAN
It's well you're here, officers.
Our unwell former dog warden, Doug
Fennel, absconded with our dear
dog, Rilke. Ruffed up my sister,
Margot, here, while I slept.

MARGOT
Wallosed me with an orange.

CRASHAW
Do you know toward where the man
and mutt amissing might be to?

MARGOT
No idea.

MORGAN
It's tragic, really.

MARLOWE
Let us know should you learn of his
heading. We'll be aheading, too,
then.

CRASHAW
Ahunting.

MORGAN AND MARGOT
(together)
Thank you, officers.

EXT./INT. WHITE VAN - NIGHT

The white van pours out smoke on the side of the road next to
Kissimmee prairie. One of the rear doors has popped open.

Rilke stumbles out of the rear and limps off into the
prairie, blood running down his leg.

Worm and Snake are konked out in front, the airbags having been deployed.

Doug wakes up, looks around, and sees that Rilke is missing.

DOUG

Rilke?

He struggles to get out and eventually works himself to the rear, falling out. He notices a small trail of blood leading into the prairie.

DOUG

What have I done?

He gets up and limps into the prairie, following the blood.

EXT. RILKE'S SPOT - DAY

As the sun rises, Rilke is lying down in the prairie, the same spot as that in the beginning. He is barely alive.

Doug approaches him and gets on his knees to pet him.

DOUG

My sweet king. What have I done?

Rilke wheezes. Doug looks around the prairie.

DOUG

This is what you wanted all along
... This is what you meant ...

Rilke wheezes and dies in Doug's lap. Doug weeps.

DOUG

How did I not understand. Unheard
... this is what you meant ... this
is what you meant ...

Doug gets up and walks toward the van.

EXT. WHITE VAN - DAY

Doug gets back to the van and retrieves a full-sized spade and the gun from the back. He walks back toward Rilke.

EXT. RILKE'S SPOT - DAY

Doug gets back to Rilke, puts the gun on the ground, and starts digging a three-foot-ish hole. After getting half-way through, he starts to recite a sonnet while still digging.

DOUG

When I consider everything that
grows / Holds in perfection but a
little moment. / That this huge
stage presenteth nought but shows/
Whereon the stars in secret
influence comment. / When I
perceive that men as plants
increase, / Cheered and checked
even by the self-same sky: / Vaunt
in their youthful sap, at height
decrease, / And wear their brave
state out of memory. Then the
conceit of this inconstant stay, /

He finishes digging. He picks up Rilke and kisses him on the forehead. He places Rilke gently in the hole. He covers Rilke with dirt while finishing the sonnet.

DOUG

Sets you most rich in youth before
my sight, / Where wasteful Time
debateth with Decay / To change
your day of youth to sullied night,
/ And all in war with Time for love
of you, / As he takes from you, I
engraft you new.

He finishes the hole and drops the shovel.

DOUG

Rilke ... Pebbles ... fate over-
rules, and I am amongst the million
that fail.

Doug picks up the gun. He puts it to the side of his head, pulls the trigger, and slumps to the ground with a bang.

EXT. WHITE VAN - DAY

An ambulance and firetruck arrive at the white van. A fireman follows the trail of blood.

BLACK SCREEN

SUPER: "One Year After the Death of the Baroness"

INT. ESTATE / BALLROOM - DAY

A funeral reception for Rilke. Pictures of Rilke fill the room. Many guests mill about, including Charita and Truss.

Worm and Snake eat deviled eggs in a corner. Margot sits at a prominent table spooning Vegemite, with headphones on.

Morgan finds Truss and goes to speak with her.

MORGAN

In spite of its aitos, I must thank you, Ms. Truss, for your untiring help with the estate transfers. We couldn't do it without you.

TRUSS

Of course, of course. Now, as you know, the funds will be in escrow for the next six months, pending no further changes.

MORGAN

Absolutely.

The doorbell rings. Morgan goes to answer it.

INT. ESTATE / FRONT DOOR - DAY

Morgan opens the front door. Terra is on the other side with a small metal kennel.

TERRA

Hi, Mr. Ehrlich. You might not remember me.

MORGAN

Of course I do. You're the citrus-slash-dog breeder.

Morgan looks inside the kennel and is upset to find two German Shepherd puppies.

TERRA

Yes, that's me. Hopefully this will make recent events less sour. I've brought Rilke's pups.

MORGAN

From the surreptitious tryst.

TERRA

Yes, that's the one. I've got the lineage documents here as well. That man, Mr. Fennel, he'd already paid me. So, these sweeties get to stay with you, if you'll have them.

MORGAN

Absolutely. We thought his line had died forever.

TERRA

I'm glad.

Terra hands Morgan the box.

MORGAN

You're welcome to join us, too. We're celebrating Rilke's life at this very moment.

TERRA

Thanks so much.

They both go inside.

INT. ESTATE / BALLROOM - DAY

Morgan enters carrying the kennel. He and Margot lock eyes. Morgan finds Truss again.

MORGAN

Well, Ms. Truss, it appears that fortuna has brought forth changes after all.

Morgan gets on a chair and addresses the crowd.

MORGAN

Everyone. It just so happens, in our day of grief, Fortuna's catered youthful-yelped relief. I present to you, with joy: Rilke Wolfmann Ehrlich V and Fortuna Ehrlich I.

Morgan takes out the puppies and shows the crowd. Everyone applauds and sighs.

He puts them on a table nearby. People take turns going up and petting the puppies.

Suddenly, Worm's caiman springs out of a vent and into the room. It lunges toward the puppies. Worm drops his eggs and jumps up, sprinting toward the caiman.

Morgan picks up the puppies to protect them and moves closer to Margot.

WORM

Everyone make way! That's my buddy!

Worm grabs a large potted plant, dumps the plant, and traps the caiman inside the pot. He turns over and looks in the pot. He pets the caiman on the top of the head.

The crowd cheers. Charita goes up to Morgan and Margot.

CHARITA

I'm so happy I'll be able to stay
with you after all, with these
beautiful animals.

MORGAN

Yes, absolutely. We'll arrange
accommodations right away.

MARGOT

You're on toenail duty, wizardess.

CHARITA

Oh my.

MORGAN

If you will all briefly excuse me.
Here, Margot, take my cup.

Morgan hands the puppies to Margot. He walks out of the room toward his office.

INT. MORGAN'S OFFICE - DAY

Morgan enters his office and sits down at his desk. He pauses, tired, then opens a drawer.

He pulls out a gun and puts it on his desk. He sits back and stares at it for a while, thinking.

EXT. RILKE'S SPOT - DAY

A light breeze flows through the grass. Rilke sits in the spot where he died. His puppies appear in the prairie where, previously, sheep had been roaming. Rilke barks at them.

Doug, Gibble, and Colin Mochrie watch Rilke, holding hands.

Pebbles walks into the scene from a distance, sprinting aggressively toward Rilke, hissing. Rilke whimpers and looks toward the camera, then back toward Pebbles.

BLACK SCREEN

MID-CREDITS

INT. ESTATE / MORGAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Morgan sits at his desk, Gable across from him. Gable holds his shotgun. Morgan's gun rests on his desk.

GABLE

"Then said I, Lord, how long? And
he answered, Until the cities be
wasted without inhabitant, and the
houses without man, and the land be
utterly desolate."

MORGAN

You about done?

FADE OUT.